

SIR OTONDE MICHAEL -DELEGATE



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AEN 301 – DISCOURSE ANALYSIS

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1. INTRODUCTION

This module is an introduction to the analysis of language as it is used by people in their everyday communication. The kind of analysis of language presented here breaks away from the traditional and most common analysis of linguistic features concerning form and structure of units such as the: phoneme, morpheme, word, phrase, clause and sentence. Attention of learners is drawn to the idea that an analysis of language should, among other things, consider the context in which the language is used. Various approaches to the description of language as it is used by people in their daily interactions are explored. The module introduces learners to the idea that just as one can describe the structure of a sentence using grammatical rules, so can one describe the structure of discourse – language that is occurring for communication, such as a conversation or passage, using functional terms – that is, the function the language user fulfils by producing the linguistic string in context.



2. OBJECTIVES

The general expectations of the student after studying this module are that the students will:

- (i) Be aware that in their everyday communication, people use language that is well structured and appropriate in context; and that such language is expected and appreciated; and that there are linguistic means of describing such language.
- (ii) To be able to provide linguistic descriptions of language that people use in their everyday communication.
- (iii) To be able to differentiate appropriate discourse from inappropriate discourse.
- (iv) To be able to communicate with other people using well structured discourses that effectively fulfill both social and informational goals of human communication.

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LECTURE 1

THE NATURE OF DISCOURSE



1.1 INTRODUCTION

In this lecture you will learn that a discourse is language occurring naturally in a social situation for the purpose of communication. It communicates a message from one person to another or from a source to a receiver. You will understand that a discourse can be short or long as long as it communicates a message in context.



1.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Address the question - What is discourse?
- Understand the properties of discourse
- Understand the assumptions of Discourse Analysis
- Identify the features of context of a discourse
- Differentiate between the concepts 'Discourse' and 'Text'



1.3 WHAT IS DISCOURSE?

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One may define discourse as a unit of linguistic analysis (i.e., a unit of language) which is beyond the sentence level. In other words Discourse is a supra-sentential language unit.

It is beyond the sentence:

- Not necessarily in terms of size,

But most importantly:

- In terms of the discourse properties,

When a discourse has occurred what has happened is not the construction of a sentence/sentences, but the communication of a message.

Hence discourse may also be defined as:

- Language in Use, or:
- Language which has been produced as a result of an act of communication.

Unlike the sentence, what distinguishes a discourse is not conformity to grammatical rules, but, the fact that;

- It communicates, and
- It is recognized as having unity.

The Size of a Discourse

In terms of size (physical size – what is seen or heard), a discourse can take the forms as follows:

- i) It can be as small short as a: WORD – in, out, stop, exit, entrance,
: A SIGH – mh!
: An EXPLETIVE/EXCLAMATION – ups! Ooh!
Aha!

ii) It can be:

- a sentence: “She is not here”
- a short conversation – A: How are you?
B: I’m fine.
- a scribbled note : ‘Remember dad’s birthday pen’
- a notice on the Notice board
- a lecture.
- a record of parliament proceedings
- a lengthy legal case (e.g., the Goldenberg inquiry)
- a novel or text book.

iii) It can be A whole social interaction or event: e.g.,

- Telephone conversation,
- Interview
- Debate of various kinds of discussions
- Church service
- Wedding ceremony
- Fundraising party
- Burial ceremony
- Welfare meeting
- Political home coming party

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- Political rally
- An AGM of a school or prize-giving day

You could even have sub-discourses within a discourse.

It could be any of the above and it will be a discourse as long as:

- it is communicating a message
- it is recognized by its receivers as coherent – having unity of meaning/content from the beginning to the end.



Can you think of and write down a discourse you participated in some time today?

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1.4 DISCOURSE PROPERTIES

Discourse has the following fundamental properties:

1. It is a complete communicative unit: Complete in the sense that it has an identifiable beginning and end, and it conveys a complete message.
2. It has an identifiable structure. The structure is describable in functional terms. The functional terms which describe the structure are determined by a consideration of contextual features as well as formal features of the discourse.
3. It has Contextual Features which aid its creation and interpretation. That is, it is produced in context; it conveys meaning which is interpreted in context. It occurs within a social interaction where it accomplishes action – i.e., it performs some action within a particular social context.
4. It has a topic and information structure which can be described (explained) in terms of Theme and Rheme or Given and New information. This is particularly so when the discourse is occurring for transactional purposes.
5. It has unity which is seen in terms of cohesion and coherence.

These same properties are considered to be among the major assumptions of discourse analysis. The following are other Assumptions of Discourse Analysis.



1.5 ASSUMPTIONS OF DISCOURSE ANALYSIS

Discourse Analysis operates from the following major assumptions:

1. Language always occurs in context

Since Language always occurs in context Discourse Analysis seek to find out:

- In which specific context was a particular linguistic occurrence produced and interpreted?
The context include:
 - The cultural set up where there are shared meanings and world views.
 - The Social context in which both self and others draw upon institutional and interact ional orders to construct definitions of situation and action.
E.g., wedding ceremony, burial, party celebrating certain achievements.
- Language is embedded in context. So Discourse Analysis must seek to find out how language is used in the context. They ask – is language necessary in a context? If so for what purpose? It is used, for example, to instruct, appease, order, applaud, blame, control, etc.

2. Language is context sensitive

When Language occurs in context, its pattern with regards to form and function (at the surface level) and (at the underlying level) will be sensitive to the features of the given context. There is a systematic relationship between language and context. The systematicity is at all levels – i.e. Phonological, morphological and syntactic levels.

Constraints on language form and function are drawn from: cultural, social, psychological and textual domains. E.g. Labov's study of Black youths in the Ghetto parts of New York – the social background affects their grammar. E.g. cultural propositions influence the structure of narratives, for example, oral narratives – openings and closings of stories differ from culture to culture.

3. Language is always communicative.

Language is always from a sender/producer and is addressed to a recipient. Language bears a message –which may be informative or interactive. An Informative message must inform the receiver of some news he/she does not have. It communicates something. An Interactive message reflects feelings; they modify our behaviour. Language is communicative in that it occurs within a shared domain. Actual communication occurs when a sender gives his intended information/message and the receiver receives it. In short:

- It is directed towards a recipient immediate or eventual.
- It is intended to be so directed
- It is attended to by a recipient.

4. Language is designed for communication.

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The design involves two things:

- a- Language has a code, with unrestricted displacement in time and place.
- b- Language has certain specifically designed features that contribute to the ease with which it can be used as system of communication. Such are the:
 - sound structure
 - word structure
 - sentence structure flexibility to allow focus, topicalization, stress, emphasis, etc
 - Organization of information e.g., idea connectors
 - The use of choice of reference terms / items etc.



1.6 THE CONTEXT OF SITUATION OF A DISCOURSE

1.6.1 Introduction ???

One of the major assumptions of Discourse Analysis is that language always occurs in context. This, in simple terms, is to say that Language is used in an environment by people who are doing something. Therefore, in discourse analysis, in order to determine what gives a stretch of language unity and meaning we must look beyond the formal rules operating within the sentences and consider the context in which the language occurs and is interpreted. That is, its context.

In general sense Context is the knowledge of the world outside Language, which we use to interpret it (language). The world outside language includes:

- Cultural and social relationships of participants.
- What we know and what we assume the speaker / hearer knows about the topic of discourse.
- The features of the physical environment present (setting)
- Also some knowledge of the text itself (form)

Thus in looking at context we go beyond language into the mind, the body, the society, and the physical world. These are in addition to the linguistic form.

Meaning varies with context. Formally, out of context, a sentence has a kind of time-free and place - free meaning. When used as an utterance in context, it may have meanings which although connected to the context free sentence meaning may be extremely varied. An Utterance can mean anything. The context of situation in which an utterance occurs will determine whether the utterances in a discourse are making sense together; are unified as a discourse, is a structured supra-sentential stretch of language.

1.6.2 The Features of Context

Specifically the Features of context of situation in which a piece of discourse occurs according to Hymes (1972) include:

- The Persons participating in the discourse
- The Topic of the discourse
- The setting
- The Channel

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· The Code
· The Event

· The Message Form

1.6.2.1 THE PERSONS PARTICIPATING.

The Persons participating in the discourse or speech event are also known as Participants. They are:

- a) The Addresser : The speaker /writer who produces the utterance in order to transmit or send out a message
- b) The Addressee: The hearer or reader who is the intended receiver of the utterance. The message is sent to him/her and he receives it.
- c) The Audience: The person / people who actually receive the utterance, including the over hearer. Thus, The Audience includes those to whom the message is directed together with those who just happen to hear it by chance.

The role of the participants in discourse production, interpretation and analysis is as follows:

- Knowledge of the addresser in a given communicative event (discourse occurrence) makes it possible for one to imagine what that particular person is likely to say, so he is able to categorize the speech act or function
- Knowledge of the addressee restricts the analyst's expectation even further (e.g., Teacher saying to a naughty child who's been missing school: "I am pleased to see you"; or, teacher when teaching about humour to a literature class, asks the students: "What are you laughing at?")
- Knowledge of the addressor, addressee and even audience will help an analyst determine the structure of the discourse. He will know for example, who is controlling the topic? There are cases where the degree of control over the topic is invested in one person (e.g., Classroom discourse). In such a situation the coordination of Turn-taking is invested in one person. This is because of the status difference between the participants. The status difference between participants may come about as a result of two things (i) acknowledged superior expertise – where the information comes from; (ii) situationally assigned roles – e.g., role of leader in committee meetings.
- Another knowledge which is helpful to the analysis with regard to the participants is familiarity between the participants – e.g., can they joke? Is it only serious information.
- Knowing the participants will also make it possible for one to know the likely purpose of the interaction: so that you know the actions likely to be taking place; whether there is one or more than one goals being achieved within the single interaction.

1.6.2.2 THE TOPIC OF THE DISCOURSE

This is what is being talked about. The role of TOPIC in helping the interpretation has to do with: Limitation of the expected interpretation e.g., What are you laughing at if the TOPIC is HUMOUR in a literature class is seeking the learners to explain about humour. And Where there

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are some words with different meanings like bank - of river and bank – of money institution – where you must know the topic to tell what the word means.

1.6.2.3 SETTING.

The features considered as setting are:

- Location in terms of place - Where the discourse is taking place.
- Location in terms of time – When the discourse is taking place.
- The physical relations of the participants with respect to posture, gesture and facial expression.
- The physical objects present in the location

These will help in the production and interpretation, particularly when it comes to deictic forms and general word – where the meaning has to come from the context. For example, a time word like ‘yesterday’ has no meaning unless you know the specific date of speaking. Also a deictic words like ‘here’ and ‘this’ rely on the context for their meaning in the discourse.

1.6.2.4 CHANNEL

This specifies how the contact between the participants in the discourse is being maintained. E.g., is it by speech, writing, singing or other signals (e.g., drumming, whistling).

Role: Speech is likely to take the form of a conversation, signals, Writing is likely to be long in form.

1.6.2.5 CODE

This is the language or dialect or style of Language that is being used.

Role: A knowledge of the code being used is helpful in determining the units of discourse especially at the higher ranks (e.g., in a business meeting, mother tongue may be used at the greetings and then the code changes as the serious discussion begins). Also the code can help determine the purpose for the discourse.

1.6.2.6 MESSAGE FORM

This is the kind of presentation format used e.g., chat, debate, sermon, fairy-tale, letter, report, conversation, discussion.

Role: The Analyst will be able to tell for example that the chat will be organized as a conversation where the turns to speak alternate; A sermon will have at least a long inform/persuasion.

1.6.2.7 EVENT

This is the social event within which the discourse is occurring. For instance, you could have a social gathering, a party, church service, a burial. Within the social event there may be various small discourses; the main address e.g., by the chief guest, and the small conversations among the participants.

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These are the contextual features which would guide a discourse analyst in his identification, interpretation and categorization of the discourse occurrence.



1.7 THE NOTIONS 'DISCOURSE'/ 'TEXT'

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In the following sections you will be learning more about what Discourse Analysis is all about. As you read on you will be encountering the notions Discourse and Text used interchangeably. You therefore, need to understand how these notions have been used in studies of discourse.

Traditionally the concern of linguistic analysis had been mainly limited to language units within the sentence (e.g., the sounds of words, patterns of sounds in the words, word structure, word meaning, and the structure of the sentence). In recent years (i.e., beginning in the early 70s) there has been an increasing interest in the analysis of stretches of language extending beyond the sentence. For instance, analyzing the way sentences work in sequences to produce coherent stretches of Language.

Since the onset of this interest in the analysis of supra-sentential structures in the field of Linguistics, there have been two different areas of focus in the study.

1. Some studies focus on the analysis of structures of naturally occurring **spoken language**, such as, conversations, interviews and speeches. Some scholars use the term **Discourse Analysis** specifically for the structural description of naturally occurring **spoken discourse**.
2. Other studies are concerned with the structure/organization of **written language** above the sentence as found in such texts as essays, passages, chapters, notices, instructions, road signs and so on. Some scholars use the term **Text** specifically to refer to this analysis of **written text**.

Thus sometimes a distinction is made between **Discourse Analysis** and **Text Analysis**, whereby Discourse Analysis refers to the analysis of spoken interaction; and Text Analysis refers to the analysis of written passages. Also a distinction is made between –

Discourse: supra - sentential spoken language, or a structured event manifested in linguistic (and other) behaviour, and,

Text: supra - sentential written language structured into a unitary whole.

These distinctions can be represented by using the following simplistic matrix, where a linguistic occurrence is assigned the different features as follows.

[-Supra-sentential], [-Use] = THE SENTENCE

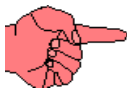
[+Supra-sentential], [-Use] = THE TEXT

[-Supra-sentential], [+Use] = THE UTTERANCE

[+Supra-sentential], [+Use] = THE DISCOURSE

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Note



The way use is used here emphasizes the action the speaker is currently performing by an utterance.

This distinction that is sometimes made between Discourse Analysis and Text Analysis is neither clear nor important. It is not clear because it depends on the particular features that the analysts want to emphasize: if they want to look at, for instance, a written essay with complete sentences to establish its lexico-grammatical links, they can call it Text Analysis. If they want to look at the relationship between utterances in a conversation, or the moves made by speakers to introduce a new topic, topic change, etc, they can choose to call it Discourse Analysis. What is important is that both 'Discourse' and 'Text' can be used in a much broader sense to include all language units with a definable communicative function, whether spoken or written. Some scholars talk of spoken and written discourse; others talk of spoken and written text.

Note



In this unit you must have realized we use the terms text and discourse interchangeably, as we:

- (1) describe and analyze the units of spoken discourse/conversation; and
- (2) study to a limited extent certain features of the organization of written text, such as cohesion and coherence; Theme and Rheme; Topic and Information structure.



1.8 SUMMARY

To sum up, Discourse/Text is language occurring in context for use. Discourse has specific properties and assumptions that must be considered in its description. Its analysis presents a description of language unity and meaning. The description of discourse looks beyond the formal rules operating within the sentences and consider the people who use language and the world in which it happens. The language users who produce discourse have more knowledge than just the knowledge of linguistic form and structure.

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LECTURE 2

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SPOKEN Vs WRITTEN DISCOURSE



2.1 INTRODUCTION

In Lecture 1 you learnt about the nature of discourse. In this lecture you will learn that this discourse may occur in the form of speech or writing, and that each form has its distinctive and significant characteristics



2.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Describe the features of speech and those of writing at the levels of:
 - Form / Structure
 - Manner of Production and Reception
 - Function
- Discuss the primary functions of speech and those of writing



2.3 LANGUAGE SKILLS USED IN DISCOURSE

Traditionally language teaching has been divided discourse into two major categories:

1. SPOKEN DISCOURSE
2. WRITTEN DISCOURSE

These, for purposes of language teaching and learning, are further divided into four skills:

- | | | | |
|------------|--------------|-------------|------------|
| (a) SPOKEN | 1. Speaking | (b) WRITTEN | 3. Writing |
| | 2. Listening | | 4. Reading |

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The traditional division of language into spoken and written discourse is based on the differences manifested in the following three (3) broad aspects of language occurrence:

- I Form / Structure
- II Manner of Production and Reception
- III Function

Hence to understand the nature of Spoken and Written discourse with a view to establishing the differences between the medium of human communication we may consider the following questions:

- What do they look like?
- How do they differ?
- Why the difference?

Before we address these questions we must note the fact that: both spoken and written discourse are language occurring in a social context to communicate a message. They are the same language but embodied in different media:

- >Spoken Medium and
- >Written Medium

So then,



What do they look like and how do they differ?



2.4 THE FORMS OF SPEECH and WRITING

Spoken and written discourse differ in form/structure. The difference can be seen as we may move systematically, through the levels of language from substance to discourse as we compare/contrast speech and writing.



2.4.1. SUBSTANCE LEVEL

At the level of substance (i.e. the matter, the material or the object that is called Language),

- SPOKEN DISCOURSE has phonic substance: this is the audible sound waves – the sounds we hear.
- WRITTEN DISCOURSE has graphic substance: these are visible marks on a surface. They include, complete written structures such as words and sentences; punctuation marks, such as commas, colons, hyphens, full stops, and other autographical features like capitalization and paragraphing.
-



2.4.2 PHONOLOGICAL LEVEL.

SPOKEN DISCOURSE: at the level of phonology, spoken discourse has sounds that are organized into words that we hear. It also has prosodic/ supra-segmental features – i.e., the relative loudness, and duration of syllables, variation of voice, (e.g., change in pitch of speakers' voice etc). There are also the pauses (silences) between the words and groups of words.

WRITTEN DISCOURSE has no form at the phonological level. The form of written discourse is always handled at the level of substance: the orthographic marks on the written surface. The organization is handled at the level of syntax: the ordering of word and the punctuation in the structures of a sentence; and in the combination of sentences into larger units.



2.4.3 LEXICAL AND SYNTACTIC LEVEL

SPOKEN: Lexically (at the level of words) spoken discourse is characterized by:

- (i) Fillers: E.g., well, erm, aah, ooh, um, sort of, kind of, I mean, okay, I thin, you know, if you know what I mean, of course, etc.
- (ii) A good deal of rather unspecific/generalized, vocabulary, such as: a lot of, got, do, thing, nice, stuff, place, things like that, good, bad.
- (iii) Ordinary common terms, simple choice of words, ordinary words. For example, you can tell someone that you are thinking of applying for a job; but write that you are considering submitting an application for a job. Here 'thinking' is an ordinary term, whereas 'considering' is not.

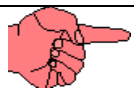


2.5.4 SYNTACTICALLY / GRAMMATICALLY (At the level of the sentence.)

SPOKEN DISCOURSE: Syntactically spoken discourse is characterized by:

- (a) Unfinished Structures – e.g.,
 - (i) Incomplete sentences which normally occur in simple sequences of phrases.
 - (ii) False Starts – e.g., A speaker may utter a phrase and then replace it or refine the expression as he goes along. Such is an instance of self correction or repair.
 - (iii) Missing Referent – In a chat about the immediate environment, the speaker may rely on, for instance, a gaze direction to supply a referent (e.g., looking at an elephant “huge, isn't it?”)
- (b) Repetitions – The speaker frequently repeats the same syntactic form several times before moving on

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Note

That the fillers, unfinished structures and repetitions are referred to as the NON -FLUENCY FEATURES of Speech. They are not part of the vocabulary or grammar of the language.

- (c) In a conversational speech where sentences occur, the sentences are normally in the form of ACTIVE DECLARATIVES (e.g., He kicked the ball.)
- (d) Whereas in written discourse, sentences are generally structured in SUBJECT –

PREDICATE FORM (He / kicked the ball.)

S P

In spoken discourse, it is quite common to have the TOPIC – COMMENT form/structure (e.g., The ball, did he kick it?)

- (e) Spoken discourse has utterances while written discourse has sentences.

WRITTEN DISCOURSE.

On the other hand, written discourse is characterized by rich lexis and organized structure. For instance,

- (i) It lacks pauses and the non-fluency features signaled by fillers, unfinished structures, and unnecessary repetitions.
- (ii) It has complete sentences, containing subordination and frequent modifications via Adjectives and Adverbs.
- (iii) It is expected to observe the rules of grammar to the letter.
- (iv) Written discourse has complete well-constructed sentences with a variety of patterns.

In general terms, while Spoken Discourse is considered to be less planned and less orderly, written discourse is considered to be formal, planned and well organized.

Discussing the Differences of SPOKEN and WRITTEN discourse in FORM and STRUCTURE

In discussing some of the differences in the form/structure of spoken and written discourse we may limit ourselves to the following observations:

- (i) Whereas speech contains non-fluency features which are not part of the vocabulary or grammar of the language, these features are absent in writing.
- (ii) That written discourse is characterized with rich lexis and organized structure
- (iii) That the non-fluency features which break the flow of speech are quite usual and necessary in spoken discourse. This is because when you speak spontaneously you are doing at least three things at a time. You are:

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- One – planning what to say next
- Two – saying what you have planned to say
- Three - monitoring what you are saying in order to ensure that it is what you mean to say.

With all these duties to perform, it is not surprising that the speaker in ordinary spontaneous speech produces conversations broken up by hesitations, false starts, self corrections, repetitions fillers and so on.

Also, the speaker, planning in the here and now time and possibly threatened by his interlocutor wanting to take the turn to speak, cannot avoid:

- Repeating himself,
- Using the same syntactic structure
- Using the first word that comes to his mind rather than hunting for a better one
- Filling in with fillers.

He does all these so that he can hold on to speaking turn until he has made his contribution to the communication of the message.

(iii) The rich lexis and well- organized structure in the written discourse, are an indication that the writer has taken time in the construction and possible reconstruction after several rewritings of the draft until the final one.

These rewritings are possible because the writer has no pressure to dispatch the information, similar to that of the speaker whose audience/hearer is waiting there and then.

In discussing the general observation that spoken discourse is less planned and organized, while writing is formal, planned and organized, we can say that:

- There are some kinds of spoken discourse that – e.g., - lessons , lectures, interviews, trials which have significant features in common with typical written discourse. These features are:
- They are also planned
- They are well-organized
- They have complete sentences and rich lexis.

Also, less formal unplanned discourse is usually associated with spoken discourse, but it could also occur in writing, e.g., scribbled notes, SMSes.

Furthermore, there are many discourse types which are intermediate cases between writing and speech: E.g. - Spoken language which is read, or learnt from a script (E.g news bulletin and plays)

- Spoken language which bases on written notes (E.g. talks and lectures.
- Dictation in class



2.5 MANNER OF PRODUCTION

Using very basic/elementary terms we can say that the entire process of communication through language involves the use of the mind, whether the language occurring is spoken or written discourse. However, there is a clear difference in their manner of production as follows:

- Speech is released using the speech organs including, the voice, the oral and the nasal cavities (mouth and nose) and received through the ears. While written discourse is released using the hands and received through the eyes.

The production and reception of discourse are both parts of discourse processing. Discourse processing occurs when a message originating from one's mind is sent out using linguistic items, occurring in context, to a receiver who then interprets the language and understands the message.

The question we want to address in specific terms is that – How does spoken discourse differ from written discourse during the processing of discourse which involves production and reception?

SPOKEN:

(a) Spoken discourse happens in time (i.e., The time here-and-now), and must therefore be produced and received “on – line”. That is, as it is being produced, it is being received.

This means that the producer has no opportunity of going back and changing / restructuring whatever he says before the receiver hears it. There is no time to pause and think while we are talking. We cannot stand back and view the discourse in order to improve it.

Thus the production of spoken discourse is produced under circumstances which are considerably very demanding.

(b) More demanding in the sense that:

- The speaker must monitor what he has just said and determine whether it matches his intentions.
- At the same time he must be producing the current utterance, and
- Planning his next utterance.

The speaker monitors not only his own performance, but also the performance of the hearer.

WRITTEN DISCOURSE

Is normally not produced and received on line. As a result, during production the writer may:

- Look over what he has already written and improve it.
- Pause between each sentence or every word, or whatever section of the writing.
- Take time in choosing an expression, even look it up in the dictionary if need be.
- Re-order what he has written and even change his mind about what he wants to say.

DISTINCTION BETWEEN SPEECH AND WRITING

The above observations point to the following distinctions between speech and writing:

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Speech is transitory, impermanent, not on records. This means that speech is on the move, passes by, diminishes or occurs and fades while writing is permanent, on record and can be retrieved in future, for future reference.

Although the speaker has much pressure during the production and perception of his speech, one advantage that he enjoys over the writer is that the speaker can observe his listener (interlocutor) and receive immediate feedback. This can then help him improve on his manner of production or even the point being made.

The writer has no access to immediate feedback, and simply has to imagine the reader's reaction. The communication effected here can be considered as one way. The speech interaction is two-way.

In addition to the advantage of immediate feedback that the speaker enjoys, there are also the following facilities that enhance effective communication in spoken discourse:

- The speaker has available to him the full range of voice quality effects, as well as paralinguistic features – i.e., facial expression, posture and gesture for his message.
- All these are not available to the writer. Therefore, the writer must make full use of linguistic features, e.g., complete sentences, clear expressions, a variety of idea connectors, modifiers. He must also make good use of punctuation features, e.g., to create emphasis and clarity, where necessary.



Note

That there are exceptional cases when writing is processed on line, as in when a teacher writes on the board as he teaches and the learners observe. Here the producer, the writer, has similar problems as the speaker.



2.6 FUNCTIONS OF THE DIFFERENT FEATURES IN SPEECH AND WRITING

In spoken discourse we have the non-fluency features: i.e. fillers, hesitations, pauses, repetitions, unfinished grammatical structures. The function of these is to achieve grammatical effects or completeness. For instance, the speaker uses them to hold on to the speaking turn until he completes his contribution to the communicative act. The same purpose is achieved in writing the well structured linguistic items and proper punctuation that occur in writing.

Also Note that the function of written punctuation marks is partly equivalent to the function of intonation, stress, and pauses in speech.

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Structure being “How the bits of information are linked and related” is present in writing. Thus the complete sentences and clauses linked by a variety of linking items – connectors, conjunctive adverbs- are found in writing to show unity of message. This function in writing is achieved in speech by repetition, stress, emphasis markers. Also the function of written punctuation marks is equivalent to the function of intonation, stress and pauses in speech. They are for organization, emphasis and clarity.



2.6.1 THE BROAD LANGUAGE FUNCTIONS

When we consider the two broad categories of the functions that human language performs, namely:

- The TRANSACTIONAL FUNCTION
 - To express content, factual information and ideas.
- The INTERACTIONAL FUNCTION
 - To express social relations, personal attitudes and feelings.

We can identify a distinction between spoken and written discourse as follows:

(1) We can reasonably suggest that in daily life in a literate culture, we use speech largely, primarily for the establishment and maintenance of human social relations – i.e., the interactional function of language. On the other hand we use writing largely, primarily for the transmission of factual information i.e., the Transactional function of language.

(2) Also written discourse is used for storage of information. For instance, a country's constitution (laws) are stored in written records. Also official meeting's minutes. Spoken language is used for information that need not be stored. E.g.....

(3) Written discourse is used for shifting information, through language, from the oral to the visual domain, making it more abstract, formal and long lasting. Spoken discourse cannot be used for such.

These different functions can be achieved because of the nature of the two types of discourse namely,

SPEECH is essentially TRANSITORY.
WRITING is designed to be PERMANENT.

Discussing the Differences in Function

It is important to emphasize the notion primarily when we say that speech is for Interactional purposes while writing is for Transactional purposes. Consider for example:

- 1 - Writing a letter to pen friends
This is writing which is interactional
- 2 - Doctor giving nurse instructions on how to administer medicine
This is speech which is transactional

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When an employer who has already been congratulated as he is told of his promotion still expects a letter, it is reasonable to say that the written discourse is for storage, record purposes rather than for conveying information because in this case the information is already conveyed.

And when an oral message is delivered to the receiver at a future time- here speech serves as storage.



ACTIVITY

Think and give more examples of the different functions of Speech and writing.

LECTURE 3

THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN LINGUISTIC FORM AND DISCOURSE FUNCTION



3.1 INTRODUCTION

In Lecture 2 you learned about the nature of spoken versus written discourse. In this lecture you will learn that there is no one - to -one relationship between linguistic form and discourse function. Nevertheless, both form and function are significant in the understanding and analysis of discourse.

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3.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Describe the features of linguistic form that occur in a discourse.
- Discuss the function performed by discourse units
- Explain why there is no one - to -one relationship between linguistic form and discourse function.



3.3 WHAT IS LINGUISTIC FORM?

Linguistic Form constitutes the following among others:

- Physical features in terms of
 - Sounds – that can be heard
 - Physical appearance – can be seen written on a page, e.g., words – ‘lecture’, sentences, clauses and phrases.
- Grammar/Syntax : Have rules which can spelt out / stated in clear and objective terms – even using rules such as: S ----→ NP + VP
- Semantic meaning : Time - free and Place-free meaning, Meaning out of context which is recorded in the dictionary, or which is conventionally agreed upon and known by everybody who knows/speaks that language.

These are the kinds of items you find analyzed in phonology, morphology, grammatical / syntactic and semantic analyses. When doing such analysis you talk of phonemes, morphemes, words, phrases, clauses, sentences and the rules that structure the units. But when you are talking of Discourse Function you talk of Utterances, Acts, Events, Messages occurring, passages, whole texts etc.

d) At the Channel /Medium level you talk of two categories of language form:

- Spoken Language
- Written Language

It is these linguistic forms that occur in Discourse, and together with other discourse properties, they perform the Discourse Functions as analyzed in Speech act theory.



3.4 WHAT IS DISCOURSE FUNCTION?

This question cannot be addressed in a straightforward manner. Approached from a BROAD LANGUAGE FUNCTIONS perspective, we can say that when language occurs in use, it is a communicative event. It may thus perform any of the following broad functions of language:

- a) Transactional Function, also known as the Ideational Function
- b) Interactional Function, also known as Phatic Communication
- c) Directive Function
- d) Expressive function
- e) Aesthetic Function
- f) Regulative function



3.4.1 THE TRANSACTIONAL FUNCTION

This function is also known as the Ideational function. Other names are: Representational (Representatives); Referential, descriptive. This is the function of language to express content. Here language is used to intentionally communicate information. The information may be in the form of factual propositions – (i.e., statements about facts). The information is transmitted from a speaker/writer who is seeking to inform the hearer/reader who receives the information about something not known to him/her. The language used to convey factual or propositional information is referred to as transactional (Brown and Yule 1983:2). In this kind of language, it is assumed that the speaker's/writer's aim is mainly to effectively transfer information. The language used is therefore message oriented and should be devoid of things like emotions. It is concerned with issues such as whether:

- the information being conveyed has enough detail
- the detail is used correctly
- the entire message is clearly represented

Examples of transactional language use include the language that occurs when:

- one gives direction to a traveler
- a doctor tells a nurse how to administer medicine to a patient
- one is giving a lecture to a class
- one writes a reimbursement claim.
- a shopkeeper explains the difference between two items
- a scientist describes an experiment
- a lecturer explains a point
- etc.



3.4.2 THE INTERACTIONAL FUNCTION OF LANGUAGE

Also known as the Phatic or Interpersonal use of language. This is the use of language to establish and maintain social relationships.

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Much of everyday human interaction is composed of the interpersonal use of language. This use involves for example:

- the conventional use of language to open talk/exchange (greetings) and to close the (leave taking)
- the use of language to negotiate role relationships, peer solidarity etc
- The use of language to acknowledge the presence of a fellow human being _ e.g., the greetings, an exchange of small talk about the whether at the office, at the bus stage, in the morning

E.g.,

Small talk at the bus stage

A: Have you been here long?

B: Yes yes

A: You are waiting for 45

B: Yeah yah

A: It is so late today

B: It usually is

A: Ah! Here it comes!

The primary function in such talk is to fulfill the human desire to interact with a fellow human being. It is difficult to suppose that the primary intention of these speakers is to seek and convey information. All they are doing is to indicate a readiness to be friendly and to talk.

Indeed a great deal of everyday conversation appears to consist of an individual commenting on something which is present to both the speaker and the listener. Hence, not much transfer of information.

Another common example of Interaction function of language is found in gossips.



3.4.3 THE OTHER FUNCTIONS

The other functions listed above are:

- g) Directive Function – to influence other's behaviour
- h) Expressive function – to express feelings
- i) Aesthetic Function – to display linguistic artifact
- j) Regulative function - to regulate self behaviour

All these in one way or the other may be considered to fall under Transactional or Interactional Functions above.



3.4.4 SPECIFIC DISCOURSE FUNCTIONS

These are known as Speech Acts, following the Speech Act Theory. They are identified at the level of Utterances (which could be sentences, clauses, phrases, words or smaller/longer

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structures) When an utterance occurs in real life communication it may perform any of the following functions/acts:

- Inform – give information
- Ask/inquire – ask information
- Command – issue a directive
- Exclaim – express strong feelings or attitudes
-

All these functions have been identified by studies of language at the sentence level (hence the 4 functional types of sentences: Declaratives, Interrogatives, Imperatives and Exclamations).

Discourse Analysis has identified the above plus many other speech acts that include:

- Promising, greeting, taking leave, issuing a threat, joking arranging discourse
- Instructing, releasing tension, undermining, scolding, blaming, praising,
- Requesting, condemning, ridiculing, scorning, advising, warning, blessing.

They may be discussed more under units of spoken discourse and speech act theory



3.5 WHAT IS THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN LINGUISTIC FORM AND DISCOURSE FUNCTION?

This is another difficult question to address.

As we have seen the linguistic occurrences within discourse may take the forms of: words, phrases, clauses, sentences. (which are considered in discourse as utterances), and Written discourse and spoken discourse (at the medium level)

In an attempt to address the question of relationship between Linguistic Form and Discourse Function, one looks at what linguistic occurrences are expected to perform the various discourse functions;

Hence we can say that:

- At the broad /medium level – Speech versus Writing: Speech is primarily Interactional whereas Writing is primarily Transactional. Note that we say PRIMARILY because writing does not always inform, and speech does not always socialize (establish and maintain social relationships). Either can do either function at certain times.
- At the level of utterances and looking at specific acts, we can say that: According to the rules of grammar there are the functional types of sentences which are expected to perform functions as follows:
 - o DECLARATIVES – make statements: their discourse function is transactional – they give information about the state of affairs in the world.
 - o INTERROGATIVES – ask questions: their function is to elicit information regarding states of affairs in the world.
 - o IMPERATIVES – MOODLESS STRUCTURES- These give commands, directives: they are considered transactional.
 - o INTERJECTIONS, EXCLAMATIONS – express feelings: they are interactional.

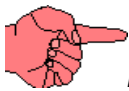
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All the forms listed above do also perform the interactional function – since they are the forms which occur when participants are interacting socially.

However, according to the “rules” of Discourse Analysis the situation is more complex. In the first place, the linguistic occurrence within discourse, as language in use, perform so many functions over and above the one listed according to the rules of grammar. Secondly, when you consider the context of a linguistic occurrence, you find that any one clause type (Declarative, Interrogative etc) may perform any function, the expected one plus any of the others. In fact the structural configuration of the SUBJECT and PREDICATE of a clause gives no reliable indication in itself of the function being performed. And, this is particularly the case with Declarative and Interrogative structures.

It is very easy, for instance, to construct a situation/context in which all the following would be heard as issuing a directive:

- Can you shut the door? (yet it is An INTERROGATIVE)
- Would you mind shutting the door (also an INTERROGATIVE)
- I wonder if you can shut the door (a DECLARATIVE)
- The door is still open (Also a DECLARATIVE)
- The door (MOODLESS)
- Shut the door (the only IMPERATIVE)



Note

Thus, that the relationship between Linguistic form and Discourse function is that **There is an obvious lack of fit / match / one to one meaning relationship, between Grammatical Form and Discourse Function.**

This is to say that in Discourse Analysis, we cannot simply assume that, for instance, if an interrogative clause occurs at some point in the discourse then it must be an elicitation. No, it could be doing anything depending on the context. It could even be a Directive.

In Discourse Analysis it is important to distinguish between what is said (form), and what is done (function) .

This is because the units of Analysis in Discourse Analysis are not grammatically defined clauses or sentences, but are functional units which may even be realized by a single word, a clause, or any kind of utterance, or even a non-verbal behaviour.

Thus any attempt to characterize discourse structure must confront the problem of Form-Function miss match, and address the questions

- How do you tell what the grammatical form is doing?
- How do the grammatical forms realize a multiplicity of functions? And,

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- How can a hearer correctly interpret which function is intended by the speaker?



ACTIVITY

Consider the following example of a discourse;

A: I wish to explain my lateness:

B: Yes.

A: The bus was late

B: I don't think I am going to listen to that excuse

A: (Leaves the room)

B: Can you shut the door

A: (Shuts the door)

And state the discourse function of each utterance.



3.6 SUMMARY

We cannot rely on structural form in determining discourse category all the time. We need to consider the context. So we must know the Features of Context and we must understand what Speech Act Theory says about 'How to do things with words'.

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BY OCHIENG BRIAN MASJID

LECTURE 4

UNDERSTANDING DISCOURSE ANALYSIS



4.1 INTRODUCTION

In Lecture 3 you learned that there is no one to one relationship between Linguistic form and Discourse function. In this lecture you will find out more about the concerns of Discourse Analysis. You will address the question: What is Discourse Analysis? Language scholars over the years have studied Discourse and seen that, in spite of the fact that Discourse can be very long, there are ways and means of establishing and describing the parts that build up a discourse unit. In this chapter you will learn the ways in which language beyond the sentence may be analyzed in to structural parts. The lesson introduces you to some ways and means of studying and understanding how it is that a discourse unit can be segmented into parts and described using straightforward categories, almost like the sentence is usually described using its constituent parts



4.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Name some approaches to the study of Discourse.
- Identify and differentiate the Units of Discourse established by the different approaches to the study of Language beyond the sentence
- Compare and contrast the units of analysis by the different approaches to the study of Discourse
- Distinguish some of the methods used in the analysis of discourse by the different approaches to the study of discourse

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4.3 WHAT IS DISCOURSE ANALYSIS?

Generally speaking, Discourse Analysis is the branch of language study that attempts to study the organization of Language above the sentence or the clause. The Units analyzed in Discourse Analysis are usually large ones such as:

- Conversational Exchanges
- Written Passages
- Lectures
- Interviews

Such Units are considered to be naturally occurring. They may occur in the written form, as in passages, articles in a newspaper, articles in a book, notices on the notice board; or they may occur in the spoken form as in teacher talk in the classroom, a conversation between friends or strangers, or a formal interview. Discourse Analysis deals with the analysis of language units in their social contexts where they are occurring in use. The units are not isolated or removed from their natural context. They are studied within that same context. Hence the object of study in Discourse Analysis is described as: naturally occurring, observable and conveying meaning, which is perceived by the participant as unified. It is not made up or coined. The object of study in Discourse Analysis differs from the object of study in grammatical analysis which are isolated sentences that have been made up / coined / invented or removed from their contexts. Sentences are idealized examples studied for grammatical well-formedness, unlike the units of discourse analysis that are studied for appropriateness of use and coherence.

Discourse Analysis considers language not only as a formal system, but also as part of a wider social and psychological context, where the people using language are engaging in some kind of social activity. Thus, Discourse Analysis looks at language in its social context, and not as a coined object out of context.



4.4 HOW DISCOURSE IS ANALYZED?

Like any other kind of analysis, Discourse Analysis involves the breaking down of discourse into component parts and describing the parts. This is done in light of the fact that Discourse Analysis deals with language in use, which cannot be adequately described by simply considering their Linguistic form. The description of discourse units considers the linguistic form as well as the functions the forms serve while in use by human beings. The description involves looking at how the linguistic forms are used to serve human social affairs. In this way Discourse Analysis differs from Sentence Analysis in that it does not consider only the formal features of language, but it looks at the formal as well as the social and Psychological features of the language under observation.

Basing its description on the formal, social and psychological characteristics of language occurrence, Discourse Analysis does the following:

- identify the different units of discourse;
- explain how they are characterized functionally, and

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- formulate principles that guide discourse users in producing and interpreting discourse.

To do the above, the description by discourse analysts must take into account features outside the language (i.e., formal linguistic features) such as:

1. The situation in which the language is occurring or is being used.
2. The people involved – what they know, what they are doing.

These two constitute the factors that enable us to construct and analyze stretches of language as discourse, as having meaning and unity. These features outside language must be taken into consideration in Discourse Analysis because our feeling that a particular stretch of language is a discourse cannot be accounted for in the same way as our feeling for acceptability of a sentence. Accounting for sentence correctness or incorrectness can be done through our knowledge of grammar without reference to factors outside language. This cannot apply in discourse analysis where the features of context must be considered.



4.4.1 IDENTIFYING AND DESCRIBING UNITS OF DISCOURSE ANALYSIS

The units of Discourse Analysis are identified and described in functional terms. When talking about function in Discourse Analysis, we are talking about the communicative function that builds the discourse into a communicative act. For example, is the sentence seeking information or service, etc.

Identifying the discourse units means that the analyst considers the linguistics forms (i.e., the words and sentences) occurring in a social situation and recognizes the functions they are performing in that context. When doing this, analysts ask questions such as:

- What different functions are being performed?
- How are these functions realized lexico-grammatically – i.e., by which words, phrases, sentences groups of sentences?

Analysts look, for instance, at the segment of discourse formed by a word, or a phrase, or a sentence, and ask: what is that segment doing in the communication between/among the participants in the discourse:

- Is it calling one's attention?
- Is it asking a question? Or,
- is it providing information, and so on, as you can see in example [1] below.

EXAMPLE [1]: A communicative Act:

<u>PARTICIPANT</u>	<u>LINGUISTIC / BEHAVIOURAL OCCURRENCE</u>	<u>FUNCTION / ACT</u>
A:	Njeri	Summon/Attention calling

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B:	(Looks back)	Behavioural response to a summon
A:	Are you going for lunch?	Asking question
B:	Yeah	Answering the question
A:	Please wait for me.	Asking for service
B:	(Waits)	Providing service

Example [1] above presents a discourse. It is language that may occur for use. It contains both linguistic and extra-linguistic happenings. Each of the segments of the discourse, whether linguistic or not has been assigned a description in functional terms- i.e., an act. Some of the utterance functions identified in Discourse Analysis are considered as representing the basic units of discourse.

Then the next question discourse analysts ask is:

What larger structures do the basic functional units combine to form?

For example, the six functions assigned to the segments of the discourse in [1] above combine to form a unit that the Birmingham School Approach to Discourse Analysis called a Transaction (see Sinclair and Coulthard 1975; Coulthard 1985). The Sociological Approach to discourse analysis would call it a Conversation (Sacks et al, 1974). (Please read about these two approaches to Discourse Analysis in Lessons 5 and 6 below).

In this way units of Discourse Analysis are seen in a rank scale where smaller units combine to form larger ones or larger units are made of smaller ones.

Once the functions of linguistic forms and non-linguistic forms occurring in a discourse are established/determined, the regularities of their distribution are established and then they become fairly predictable and usable in categorizing/describing the structure of discourse, or, at least identifying a stretch of linguistic occurrence as a discourse.



4.4.2 MAJOR CONCERNS OF DISCOURSE ANALYSIS

One may say that Discourse Analysis is concerned with, to use Austin's (1962) words, "how to do things with words" in order to achieve effects and communicate successfully with people in particular contexts. The major concerns of Discourse Analysis may be outlined as follows:

- (i) Appreciating the view that language should be analyzed in its social and psychological context.
- (ii) Determining and describing discourse structure in functional terms. This is done by asking questions regarding the way language is used rather than what its components are.
- (iii) Establishing the general principles of interpretation by which people normally make sense of what they hear and read. This is done by asking and seeking answers to questions such as –how is it that we language users make sense of what we read in texts; understand what other speakers mean despite what they say; recognize connected as

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opposed to jumbled or incorrect discourse. This involves looking into how it is that users of language successfully take part in the complete activity known as conversation.

- (iv) Relating discourse with the speakers and hearers by and for whom it is produced. Here Discourse Analysis is concerned with:
- Specifying how speakers take and relinquish the role of speaker in a conversation
 - Explaining how social roles affect discourse options in terms of who speaks when; what can be talked about; how non verbal signaling works; and how the actual form of an utterance is conditioned by the social relationships between the participants.



ACTIVITY

Match the activities under A with the Approach to language study under B, by drawing lines to link them. One activity has been matched for you (see *) as an example.

A

Studies language for appropriateness
 *Describes formal categories
 Analyzes short and long stretches of language
 Coins data for analysis
 Analysis sentential units
 Uses isolated structure
 Works with naturally occurring structures
 Uses structures in context
 Describes functional categories
 Studies language for well-formedness

B

Discourse Analysis

***Sentence Grammar**

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4.5 SUMMARY

To sum up, in Discourse Analysis we try to find out and describe what gives a stretch of language unity and meaning. To find out this we need to look beyond the formal rules operating within the sentences and consider the people who use language and the world in which it happens, as well. As language users we have more knowledge than just the knowledge of linguistic form and structure. Discourse Analysis tries to describe aspects of this knowledge available to language users.

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LECTURE 5

BY OCHIENG BRIAN MASJID

SOME APPROACHES TO DISCOURSE ANALYSIS



5.1 INTRODUCTION

There have been several approaches to the study of language beyond the sentence. Some of these approaches originate from linguistics, while others originate from other disciplines such as Sociology, Philosophy and Cultural Studies. From Sociology originates a study of discourse known as Conversation Analysis; from Philosophy originates a study of discourse known as Speech Act Theory, while; from Cultural Studies originates a study of discourse known as Ethnography of Speaking. In this lecture you will find out about these approaches to language study that have concerned themselves with the analysis of Discourse structure and how they have tried to analyze discourse



5.2 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Name and explain some different approaches to the study of discourse
- State the differences between the approaches you explain.
- Analyze a discourse occurrence using the relevant approach for the analysis of that particular discourse.

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5.3 CONVERSATION ANALYSIS

This is a Sociological approach to the analysis of the structure of a conversation. This approach involves a particular School of Sociology known as Ethno-methodology, which is rather different from main - stream Sociology. Ethno-methodology simply means the methods used by people.

Ethno-methodologists use conversation analysis as a way of looking at society, since they argue that, most of the interaction that people engage in in life is conducted through the medium of speech. Much of our social life consists of spoken interaction with others. They believe that by studying conversation they will find out more about how people create, structure, and make sense of their world. That is, how people build the social world in which they live.

Pioneers in the sociological study of conversation are scholars such as Sacks Harvey, Schegloff Emmanuel and Jefferson Gail, 1974 – “A Simplest Systematics for the Organization of Turn taking in Conversation.” In their study of conversation they were concerned with matters such as the ones explained below.



5.3.1 ANALYSIS OF SOME OF THE CONCERNS IN CONVERSATION

Scholars in this field provided descriptions of the features of a conversation that lead to the ORDERLINESS, which is always observable in spontaneous or naturally occurring conversation. Their concerns were different from the Linguistic approaches to Discourse Analysis, which tried to assign labels to stretches of speech/language and write rules that combine the labeled units into larger hierarchical structures. Conversation analysts did not make it a priority to assign structure to the whole of a piece of data this way. They were interested mainly in the large scale organizing principles found in conversations. They proceed as follows:

1. They identified and described the large scale organizing principles such as:
 - Turn-taking, - Speaking Turns,
 - Adjacency Pairs, - Conversational Phases,
 - Topic, - Stories,
 - and large scale discourse units such as Social events.
2. They start at the point in their data where utterances can be most readily/easily identified as performing specific acts, and work out from there, exploring in general terms the features of conversation that lead to orderliness.
3. Also they pay close attention to details of speech production and timing, which, for them provide the underpinning for an account of a conversation structure.

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The Sociologists conversational analysis offers a way of looking at conversation that, while strongly motivated by the view that talk is structured, does not impose any overall categorization on it. Accounting for all the data, which is very important to many Linguistic approaches to discourse analysis, is not a high priority for conversation analysis. They describe what they can and ignore what they cannot, regarding what they cannot as a separate task for description.

The Sociologists participation in discourse analysis focuses on conversation as they attempt to answer the question: What is a conversation?



5.3.2 CONVERSATION

What is a conversation?

A conversation may be defined simply as an interactional stretch of talk involving at least two participants and taking place in a non-formalized setting such that no special rules or conventions may be said to operate (Edmondson.1980). In a normal conversation, the two or more participants take turns at speaking to each other. Only one person speaks at a time and there tends to be an avoidance of silence between speaking turns.

Conversation Structure

The structure of a conversation is characterized by a significant feature known as **Turn-taking**. In addition to Turn-taking, the other major features that characterize the structure of the conversation include:- Speaking Turns,

- Adjacency Pairs
- Conversational Phases
- Topics, and
- Stories

These are each explained in the following sub-sections.

5.3.2.1 Turn-taking

According to Sacks, Schegloff and Jefferson (1974), **Turn-taking** is the process by which the role of speaker changes from one person to another in a conversation. No overt rules for changing turns exist, yet turns change with such precision that one may formulate a loose rule for the structure of a conversation that says:

“Only one and not more than one speaker at time, except for non-ordinary situations.”

If more than or less than one party is talking in a conversation, it is noticeable immediately and participants set out to ‘remedy’ the situation and return to a state of one and only speaker.

Turn-taking involves the coordination of the speech activity which requires (ideally) that only one person engages in it a time. Turn-taking is clearly necessary in speaking, since if two or more people speak simultaneously, it is hard for each to hear and understand what the other is

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saying. Hence one of the basic facts about conversation is that the role of speaker and listener changes, and this occurs with remarkably little overlapping speech and remarkably few silences.



Note

It is important to note, however, that the rule of one speaker at a time in a conversation does not apply in all speech communities / cultures. For example, among the Kisii of Kenya it is very common to find more than one of the participants in a conversation speaking at the same time.

The point at which the change of turn occurs in a conversation is known as **Transition Relevant Place**. Participants in a conversation know how to identify and use such points with precision.

How do participant in a conversation identify the Transition Relevance Place?

In a conversation when one speaker takes the speaking turn, the other participant(s) waits until the speaker indicates that he or she has finished. The speaker does this by signaling a possible completion point. The possible completion point marks the Transition Relevance Place.

Speakers can indicate the **possible completion point in a number of ways**. These include:

- (i) Asking a question;
- (ii) Pausing at the end of completed syntactic structure
(e.g., phrase, clause/sentence)
- (iii) Nominating the next speaker.

Also, a possible completion point can be identified when other participants indicate that they want to take the speaking turn. This can be done by:

- (i) Starting to make short sounds (usually repeated) while the speaker is talking;
- (ii) Use of body shifts/movements, or facial expressions to signal that they have something to say.

Change of Speakers

Turn-taking involves change of speaking turns, which take place at transition relevant places. It also involves change of speakers. How can the participants achieve change of speaker while maintaining a situation in which at least, but not more than one speaker speaks at a time? It has been suggested (Sacks) that as a current speaker you can exercise three degrees of control over the next turn:

- (i) You can select which participant will speak next by (a) naming him/her,
(b) describing him/her (stating the position).
- (ii) You can constrain the next utterance but not select the speaker.

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- (iii) You can select neither and leave it to one of the participants to continue the conversation by selecting him/herself.

Conversation Analysis focuses on describing how the Turn-taking system is used by speakers to control the process of conversation, and to create order in it.

Break down of Conversation.

This involves overlap and silence in a conversation.

Overlap: This may occur between turns when the next speaker perceives the current as having completed his contribution. For instance, when the first speaker has produced the first pair-part of an Adjacency pair, but is still continuing.

E.g.,

A: *Where are the others? ---. I thought you were to be here at ten sharp.*

B: ----- *They are still doing the CAT .*

Overlap may also occur when a speaker intends to perform only a single conversational move but uses an address term or question tag at the end of the sentence.

E.g.,

A: *Well then, it was her fault, Sara, Wasn't it?*

B: *Yeah, she made a mistake.*

Overlap or simultaneous speech may also occur in heated arguments. This is because the desire to listen and understand is absent in such interactions. Everybody wants to impose his/her views or feelings on the other.

Silence: In addition to overlap, **Silence** or **Pause** may occur between turns in a conversation.

E.g.,

A: *Please, let's go to my room and have some tea....- It will relax your mind*

B: *SILENCE.....- Am not sure I want to take tea now*

In this example, A utters an INVITATION, and when B is still silent, A continues to give REASONS WHY B SHOULD ACCEPT the INVITATION and overlaps with A who now begins to voice his reluctance to accept the offer.

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Note

It is important to note that Turn-taking is a key element in conversation structure. It goes hand in hand with the **Speaking Turn** which is

- (i) The opportunity to assume the role of speaker:
- (ii) What is said or done when the speaking turn is held by one speaker

5.3.2.2 Adjacency Pairs.

Another very important feature in the structure of the conversation is the Adjacency Pair. For along language stretch to be considered a conversation, it must consist of at least two turns. Some turns are more closely related than others. The closely related turns are know as Adjacency pairs. The Adjacency pair has been focused on by the sociologists analyzing conversations because it readily lends itself to structural description. For instance,

- it occurs regularly;
- its structural development is predictable, and
- it has obligatory features.

An Adjacency Pair is a stretch of language consisting of two turns in which the occurrence of the first part of the pair predicts the occurrence of the second part of the pair. For instance, given a Question, regularly enough an Answer will follow (Sacks ,1967). The occurrence of the second part of the pair is so predictable that whatever occurs will be interpreted as so.

Examples of first pair part are:

- | | |
|-----------------|---------------|
| - Questions | - Greetings |
| - Leave-takings | - Challenges |
| - Offers | - Requests |
| - Complaints | - Invitations |

For some of these first pair parts the second pair part is reciprocal. For instance, **Greeting-Greeting**. For some there is only one appropriate second pair part. For example, **Question-Answer**. And for others, there are more than one appropriate second pair parts. E.g.

- Complaint -> Apology/Justification
- Invitation -> Acceptance/Rejection

Adjacency pairs are basic structural units in a conversation. For instance, they are used for opening and closing conversations, for example:

- Greeting – Hi there! – Hi!
- Leave Taking – Bye then – Bye.

Adjacency pairs also occur at the other stages of the conversation. For example, the Questions and Answers in the middle stages. Adjacency pairs are very important during the conversation for operating the Turn – taking system. They clearly make the possible completion points and enable the next speaker to avoid both gap and overlap. They present conversational contexts in which the perception of the Transition relevant place is straightforward.

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5.3.2.3 Conversational Phases

Conversational Phases is the term used to refer to the **Openings** and **Closings** of a conversation. These two are also important elements of the conversation structure as they reflect the idea that in a conversation there is usually smooth sequencing of utterances with regard to how the conversation is initiated and closed down. The condition of talking to a person, **A**, about topic, **B**, is not something that can merely be started out of nowhere or can it simply stop. It has a clearly marked opening and a clearly marked end.

Openings

In a conversation a state of talk needs to be established as the Turn-taking system is set up. The opening of a conversation is the unit that establishes the state of talk in a conversation. The opening section may typically include identifications, greetings, or routine health enquiries. The greetings, as an opening unit, is close to being universal in conversation. Greetings sometimes do not occur, but when they do not, their absence is usually noticed and perhaps complained about (E.g., in African Culture).

Two regular features of greetings are:

- (i) They must occur at the very beginning of a conversation and cannot be done anywhere else in the conversation. (Sometimes in African culture it does not occur at the beginning)
- (ii) They allow all the speakers a turn right at the beginning of the conversation.

Two examples of occasions where conversations do not have to open with greetings are:

- (i) Conversations between strangers.
- (ii) Telephone conversations. These begin with the Summon/Answer realized by the ringing tone/hallow.

Closings

The closing or ending of a conversation is also something that has to be achieved - speakers do not just stop speaking. A conversation almost always ends with an identifiable closing feature which is most of the times a closing Adjacency pair, such as:

Goodbye	-	Goodbye
Good night	-	Good night
See you	-	See you
Okay /Alright	-	Okay / Alright

It is easy to know when to open a conversation but not so easy when to end it. How do speakers know when to begin the closing sequence? The closing sequence can only occur when a topic has been ended, and the participants have agreed not to introduce any new topic.

5.3.2.4 Topics

This too is one of the large scale organizing principles in a conversation. In a conversation the topic is the information being shared, or the item of news that constitute the content of the conversation. Conversation analysts examine what is said in a conversation for its 'tellability' or news worthiness. They do this when they ask questions such as:

What is it that makes the topic newsworthy? In other words,

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what is the use telling so and so that?

A speaker who consistently produces talk that is not newsworthy is considered a bore on the one hand, but social on the other. There is therefore pressure on people to transmit relevant news/newsworthy news/topics.

A conversation that is progressing well is characterized by the smooth shift from one topic or aspect of topic to another. Speaking turns must display relevance to the topic. That is speakers must tie all their utterances topically to what has gone before.

5.3.2.5 Stories

A story is considered as any report of an event occurring in a conversation. When a participant in a conversation has an event to report he/she will need to hold the speaking turn for a relatively long time in order to narrate the full story. The story is normally a few sentences long or simply a long stretch. The participant intending to tell a story needs to seek suspension of the usual turn-taking machinery. This can be done by actually announcing your intention to tell a story.



5.4 SUMMARY

We have seen that conversation was studied by scholars from a branch of Sociology known as Ethnomethodology. Conversation is identified as a naturally occurring spontaneous speech between two or more participants and it is well ordered. The ORDERLINESS, which is always observable in spontaneous or naturally occurring conversation is created by the feature found in the conversation such as: Turn-taking, Speaking Turns, Adjacency Pairs, Conversational Phases, Topic, Stories and large scale Discourse units such as Social events. All these properties are definable in fairly predictable terms.

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ACTIVITY

1. Give two examples of issues which counted as Topics in a conversation you recently participated in.
2. Reconstruct a conversation in which you recently participated and use examples from it to illustrate any two of the features that cause orderliness in conversations
3. State one feature that distinguishes between the Sociological and the Linguistic approaches to discourse analysis.
4. What is a speaking turn and when and where does it occur?
5. Which are the units of discourse structure identified by the conversation analysts, and why do they consider those units relevant for the analysis of discourse structure?
6. what is the significance of conversation Analysis in the study of human language?



5.5 ETHNOGRAPHY OF SPEAKING

Broadly speaking, Ethnography is the scientific description of human races in terms of their social and cultural groups. In the early 70s some scholars in the field of Ethnography (E.g., Hymes, 1972) felt that Linguistics as a descriptive science of Language was not adequately handling the description of language, particularly, the way people speak. They recognized the need for a second descriptive science of Language known as Ethnography of Speaking. The scholars in this field focused on the analysis of, not simply language structure but what guides people when they speak in a social situation. The guidelines could be considered as “Rules of speaking”. Such rules specified the ways in which speakers associate particular modes/manner/way of speaking, topics and message forms, with particular settings and activities (Hymes, 1972a). Their description of ‘ways of speaking’ cover areas including the following:

- (1) The Linguistic resources available to a speaker in a situation. For instance, the different languages, channels and styles a speaker can choose from. Also how does language occur in such events? Is it speech, writing, or singing; What other signs are used? Are they for example, drumming, ululations, and etc?
- (2) The Supra-sentential structuring. For instance: how many different structured linguistic events (i.e., events during which speech is used) can a whole social event be divided into? For example, a wedding ceremony should have how many addresses: An address by the preacher; the bride and groom, the parents from both sides, the master of ceremony; etc; or how many sub events? For example, the church service, reception, honey moon?

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- (3) The rules of interpretation by which a given set of Linguistic items come to have a given communicative value: For instance, when you say X you are praising; when you say, you are blaming, and etc
- (4) The norms which govern different types of interaction. For instance, who should say what, where, when? Or, who speaks where (E.g., During courtship, among the Luo of Kenya, when the suitors visit the lady's home, an elderly male cousin of the man is the one to present the matter. The suitor himself is to talk very little or not talk at all)

In order to describe such features of discourse the Ethnographers must first of all identify the particular **Speech Community** for whom particular rules of speaking are applicable. This is because the rules of speaking vary from community to community. In other words, the ethnographers begin their task by determining the speech Community for whom to describe 'Rules of speaking'.



Can you think of and state any rule of speaking from a particular speech community to which you belong, or known to you?



5.5.1 SPEECH COMMUNITY/EVENT/ACT

What is a Speech Community?

A **Speech community** is any regionally or socially definable human group identified by a shared linguistic system (Crystal D.1985). Or, it is a group of people who form a community such as a village, a region, a nation, and have at least one speech variety in common. A speech Community not only shares Linguistic resources, but also the rules for interaction and interpretation.

Once they have identified a Speech Community, the Ethnographers then study the **Speech Events** taking place in that speech community, with a view to establishing the rules of speaking governing those events.

They define a **Speech Event** as a particular occurrence where people exchange talk to facilitate their social affairs. The Speech event can be as brief as:

- An exchange of greetings
- a visit to the shop
- a brief conversation at the office in the morning when colleagues arrive as in the following example.

EXAMPLE OF BRIEF SPEECH EVENT

A: *Hi Nekesa! how are you?*
 B: *Fine.*
 A: *You are early today.*

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- B:** *Oh yes, I got a lift from my neighbour*
A: *Mh.*

The **Speech Event** is the basic unit for analysis of a spoken interaction. (Just like the sentence is the basic unit of syntactic analysis.) The speech event is the largest unit for which one can assign a linguistic structure. That is, it is the object of analysis in discourse. It consists of utterances that are described in functional terms, such as acts. The functions of the utterance combine to form events.

In addition to the functions performed by the utterances, the other components of speech event are:

- The setting
- The participants and their role relationships
- The Message or topic
- The Key (evaluation as to whether it was good or bad (Brown and Yule 1983:37))
- The channel

Speech events combine to form social occasion, referred to as **Speech Situation**. Within Speech events you find **Speech Acts**. A **Speech Act** is the function or action performed in an utterance. Examples of such actions/acts are: requesting; commanding; questioning; and, informing.

The relationship between Speech Events and Speech Acts is hierarchical. A Speech Event may consist of a single Speech Act but will often comprise several.

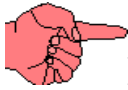
The term Speech Situation is sometimes used instead of Speech Event. But Speech Situation has a broader meaning, as we have seen above. It refers to any situation that is associated with speech and can be as long as an entire social gathering. A Speech Situation may consist of just one speech event, for instance, two people meeting in the street and having a brief conversation. Alternatively, it may contain a number of Speech Events, some going on at the same time, for example, a big dinner party.

It is not easy to find complete descriptions of “Rules of Speaking” established by Ethnographers for various speech communities. Nonetheless, the Ethnographers have made an important contribution to Discourse Analysis in their establishing of the ‘speech notions’:

- Speech Community
- Speech Situation
- Speech Event
- Speech Act (Also found in Speech Act Theory)

Which are used widely in the analysis of the structural features of discourse.

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Note

There is quite a bit of overlapping in the Sociological and the Anthropological / Cultural approaches to Discourse Analysis.



ACTIVITY

1. Reconstruct a speech event that you currently experienced and segment it into its constituent parts.
2. List all the speech acts that occurred in that speech event.
3. State one 'Rule of speaking' that you observed in that speech event.
4. What kind of Role relationships did you notice in the conversation and what were their indicators. For instance who spoke first, what did he/she say, why?



5.6 SUMMARY

In this lecture you have seen that, discourse has been being studied by scholars from different disciplines. You have seen that scholars from Sociology establish the features that lead to orderliness in a conversation. Scholars from Cultural/Anthropological studies identified the speech situations and events that may occur and the rules that guide the manner in which people speak in these events. The other approaches to the study of discourse was from Philosophy and Linguistics itself. These are explained in Lessons 6 and 7.

LECTURE 6

THE LINGUISTIC APPROACH TO DISCOURSE ANALYSIS



6.1 INTRODUCTION

In Lecture 5 you learned that in spite of the fact that discourse may be very long, i.e., covering several utterances/sentences or larger segments, there are ways and means of establishing the structural parts that build up the discourse. In this lecture you will learn the general characteristics of linguistic approaches to discourse analysis. These are the approaches that stem directly from linguistics and follow, to a large extent, the procedures of formal linguistic studies in matters of identifying and describing units of language that show discourse structure, and hence form the discourse.



6.2 OBJECTIVE

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:
Separate features that make an approach to discourse analysis a linguistic approach or otherwise



6.2 WHAT IS A LINGUISTIC APPROACH?

The approach to the study of language beyond the sentences, that stems directly from Linguistics is a linguistic approach, and is commonly known as **Discourse Analysis**. According to this linguistic approach, Discourse Analysis is the study of the organization of language above the sentence level. It deals with large units such as:

- | | |
|------------------------------|---------------------|
| - Conversational exchanges; | - Lectures |
| - Classroom talk / lesson; | - Social events |
| - Written passages or texts; | - Interviews, etc., |

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and it has structure that can be described comprehensively and completely

Like with the other approaches you have seen in Lesson 5 Discourse Analysis tries to establish regular patterns/structures that characterize the structural units of discourse.

Although Discourse Analysis stems directly from linguistics its unit of analysis is not the grammatically defined clause or clause constituents. Instead, the unit of analysis here is a higher unit that may be called language in use, or a communicative act, or a speech act (Labov, 1972) (See Speech Act Theory in Lecture 8)

Like any other kind of analysis, a Linguistic Approach to Discourse Analysis involves:

- The breaking down of discourse into component parts, and
- Describing the parts in systematic ways.

One influential Linguistic approach to discourse analysis, which you will learn about in the next lecture is the Birmingham School Approach.

Using a linguistic approach to the study of discourse you may ask and seek answers to questions such as:

- i) What are the units of discourse?
- ii) How can they be labeled and characterized?

These questions are addressed/looked at in the light of the fact that discourse is language in use - this means that the units looked for are functional and are described not in terms of their linguistic form (words and sentences that constitute them) but in terms of the function they do. Consider, for example, the following exchange:

- [1] A: *How are you?*
 B: *I am fine.*

The structure of this exchange may be analyzed in functional terms as follows:

A's utterance is an **Initiation Move (I)** (a move that begins something and looks forward) and it is performing the **Act of Question**. B's utterance is a **Responding Move (R)** fulfilling the initiation of A and performing the **Act of Answering** the question.

Since as you study the discourse function you are still working with linguistic form, other questions that you have to address as you do Discourse Analysis are:

- How many different functions are there?
- How are these functions realized lexico-grammatically?

A lexico - grammatical occurrence (i.e., a word or sentence) may fulfill a variety of functions. For example:

- Calling attention;
- Giving attention;
- Asking a question;
- Providing information, Etc.

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Consider, for example, the following exchange. The utterances of this exchange have been labeled with categories of Acts according to the Birmingham School model of Spoken Discourse Analysis and Speech act theory.

[2]	A:	Njeri!	-	Summon (Calling attention)
	B:	Looks back.	-	Response (Giving attention)
	A:	Are you going for lunch?	-	Question (Asking a question)
	B:	Year, hah.	-	Response (Answering a question)
	A:	Please wait for me.	-	Directive (Request for service)
	B:	(waits)	-	Reaction (Giving service)

The units of this example are described in functional terms. Once the functions of the linguistic forms occurring in a discourse are determined, the regularities of their distribution are established and they become predictable. For instance, it is predictable that a question will be followed by an answer.



ACTIVITY

In what ways would you consider Discourse Analysis (The Linguistics approach) different from Conversational Analysis (The Sociological approach); In what ways are they similar?



6.4 SUMMARY

A linguistic approach, as you have learned, is an approach to the study of language beyond the sentence, which originates directly from linguistics. It concerns itself with language in use in a social context. It studies such language for its structural organization. It focuses on: identifying the basic units of discourse and the larger structures the basic units combine to form. It tries to assign labels to a stretch of naturally occurring speech and writes rules or guidelines for combining the labeled units into larger hierarchical structures, thus, striving to give a structural description to the whole data starting from the smallest units to the largest ones. Scholars taking this approach to the study of discourse try to account for all the data.

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BY OCHIENG BRIAN MASJID

LECTURE 7

A LINGUISTIC APPROACH: THE BIRMINGHAM SCHOOL MODEL



7.1 INTRODUCTION

In Lecture 6 you learned that in spite of the fact that discourse may be very long, i.e., covering several utterances/sentences or larger segments, there are ways and means of establishing the structural parts that build up the discourse. In this lecture you will learn about one such linguistic approach namely, the Birmingham School approach to the study of discourse. In this approach the units of discourse are identified and described using mainly formal linguistic means. You may use the categories of units according to this approach as established by Sinclair and Coulthard,(1975; Coulthard (1985) which are an influential example of a Linguistic approach to Discourse Analysis.



7.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Describe the categories of the units of spoken discourse according to the Birmingham School approach.
- Explain the notion of RANK SCALE in the analysis of the units of Spoken discourse.
- Define and illustrate Transactions, Exchanges, Moves, and Acts.
- Segment and label – i.e., analyze – a naturally occurring Conversational exchange using these units.
- Compare and contrast Classroom talk and Everyday conversation.
- Identify where in an Interaction is a topic boundary, and where one Exchange ends and another begins.

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7.3 THE BIRMINGHAM SCHOOL MODEL OF DISCOURSE ANALYSIS

Scholars in this school postulated a level of Linguistic analysis higher than the sentence, known as discourse. They concentrated on spoken discourse, and described its structure by looking at the sequences of action/functions performed by the utterances that occur as the discourse unfolds. They tried to explain how segments of discourse combine to form larger segments/structures. They started by looking at more highly organized talk (highly organized because their structure is partly determined / imposed by social convention that stipulates, for instance: the control of subject matter, speakers, etc.). Such highly organized talk was to be found in the form of, for instance:

- Classroom discourse
- Interviews
- Law courts proceedings
- Doctor patient discourse

Studying Classroom discourse and other kinds of discourse they identified the functional units by working out how every particular utterance in a particular place in a sequence contributes to the development of the entire discourse. They identified the units of spoken discourse outlined below.



7.3.1 UNITS OF ANALYSIS AND THE RANK SCALE

The units are arranged on a RANK-SCALE. This means that they can be set out hierarchically from the lowest to the highest, or the smallest to the largest units. A Rank-scale implies that the units are related in a "consist of" relationship, with smaller units combining with other units of the same size to form larger units as, presented in the following table which shows the Rank-Scale of Syntactic units as well as those of Discourse units.

THE SENTENCE (Syntactic)	CLASSROOM DISCOURSE (Discourse)	OTHER DISCOURSES (Discourse)
- Sentence	- Lesson	- Interaction
- Clause	- Transaction	- Transaction
- Phrase	- Exchange	- Exchange
- Word	- Move	- Move
- Morpheme	- Act	- Act

This means that each unit except the smallest consists of one or more/several of the units next below it on the Rank-scale. For instance, regarding units on the table above, in the Syntactic Rank-scale:

- The **Sentence** consists of one or more **Clauses**,
- The **Clause** consists of one or more **Phrases**,
- The **Phrase** consists of one or more **Words**,
- The **Word** consists of one or more **Morphemes**,

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and in the Discourse Rank-scale:

- The **Lesson / Interaction** consists of one or more Transactions,
- The **Transaction** consists of one or more Exchanges,
- The **Exchange** consists of one or more Moves,
- The **Move** consists of one or more Acts.



7.3.2 THE UNITS OF SPOKEN DISCOURSE.

For the analysis of classroom talk/discourse, the Birmingham School (Sinclair and Coulthard, 1975) identified five discourse units or analytical categories:

The Lesson

The Transaction

The Exchange

The Move

The Act

Each of these analytical categories/units can be described in terms of the one (the unit or category) next below it on the rank scale.

(a) THE LESSON

This is the unit of the largest rank in classroom discourse. It is identified NOT LINGUISTICALLY but SITUATIONALLY. The analysts were not able to provide strict structured descriptions of a lesson in terms of the units next below it in the rank-scale other than, that it consists of Transactions. So, to identify the unit **Lesson** they relied on the school schedule as socially set. Every school has its daily programmes and, what constitutes a lesson; the beginning and end of each lesson; how long one lesson takes before another begins, is already determined along with other activities of the school. Hence the discourse analysts relied on the school schedule to determine a lesson.

(b) THE TRANSACTION

Transactions are the stages into which the lesson is divided. The Transaction is the unit next below the lesson on the rank - scale. It is formed of a series of teaching exchanges. It is marked by topic boundaries. This means that when the teacher changes topic or changes the direction the topic is going in some way, a new Transaction begins.

In Classroom discourse Transaction boundaries are typically marked by framing and focusing items referred to as **Frame** and **Focus** respectively. The Frame and Focus are pre-topic items / utterances which perform acts that are attention getting.

The Frame: Examples of Frames or framing items in English are:

Well,	Good,	Okay
Now,	Alright/Right,	

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They are produced with [+ stress, High-falling intonation, +a short pause following]

The Frames are a closed set. This means that only the words: Well, Good, Okay, Now, Alright/Right, were found to be used as Framing items in English.

The Focus: Focuses are special kinds of statements, which tell (the class) what is going to happen at a stage in the lesson. In other words they are meta-statements about the discourse. An example of focus is in the sentence below:

[1]. *Today I thought we would revise what we have learned so far about discourse analysis.*

Such a focusing statement (simply known as FOCUS) is then followed by the progress of a lesson as follows:

- [2]. (I) T: *Let's begin with the definition of discourse.*
Who can tell me what discourse analysis is?
(R) P: *It is the study of language above the sentence level.*
(F) T: *Yes, that's right! It is indeed.*
(I) T: *Now.*
What are the examples of discourse?
(R) P: ...

The utterance “**Now**” which is uttered by T in the above example is a framing item (FRAME). It is also a marker of boundaries. It marks both the Transaction and Exchange boundaries. The frame and the focus are the boundary elements in the (classroom) discourse. The frame normally precedes the focus.



Note

Note that the letters IRF that are in brackets are abbreviations for the different move categories, while the T: and P: stand for the participants in the discourse, where in this example [2] T = teacher and P = pupil

A Transaction is thus described or specified as follows:

(i) It must have a preliminary move in form of:

- a Frame and Focus
- a Frame alone, or
- a Focus alone

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- (ii) It must have at least one medial move which carries the information being transmitted. The medial move contains at least one of the following items of structure:
- an Elicitation (i.e., an utterance asking for information)
 - an Informative (i.e., an utterance giving information)
 - a Directive (i.e., an utterance requesting for/demanding action)
- (iii) It could have a terminal move, which is a concluding statement. However, this does not have to be there. The concluding statement could be left out.



Note

It is important to observe that in classroom discourse a Transaction may be marked clearly because of the socially defined roles of the participants and, particularly, the purpose of the interaction. The teacher, lecturer or seminar leader, being the guide, has a role to divide up the lesson/interaction into manageable chunks. He/she makes the structure of the lesson/interaction as clear as possible by directing it forward and summarizing points retrospectively.

In other types of discourse - there may be no obvious reasons for any of the participants to produce focusing moves. Therefore, it is normal to have interactions that have no clearly marked Transaction boundaries; or where Transactions are only marked by Frames, and no Focus.

(c) THE EXCHANGE

Smaller than the Transaction in the Rank-scale of the classroom discourse units is the Exchange. The Exchange is the unit concerned with negotiating the transmission of information. The transmission of information involves the following:

- (i) The information/message to be transmitted. The minimum amount of information, in an exchange is a complete proposition. A proposition is a unit of meaning expressing a single action or state (PREDICATE) and the participants or entities involved in the state or action. It is the basic meaning that a sentence or clause expresses. (Where you have the Subject/Argument – i.e., something, which is being named or talked about, and the assertion or predication – what is being said about the Argument - something).
- (ii) The Participant who already knows/has the information (i.e. the primary knower)
- (iii) The participant to whom the information is imparted/or to be imparted. (i.e., the secondary knower).

Also the exchange is the unit within which Turn-taking is predictable. The opening of an exchange sets up an expectation that turns would be taken until the information is successfully transmitted or communicated.

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The Exchange divides into MOVES. Most of the classroom data had been easily analyzable into three move exchanges structured in the following functions:

- INITIATION - The teacher asks a question.
- RESPONSE - The pupil gives A BRIEF ANSWER.
- FEED BACK - The teacher closes the exchange with an evaluation and then moves on to initiate another exchange.

In other discourses it is not immediately obvious what constitutes an Exchange. It is particularly difficult to distinguish a new INITIATION from THE FOLLOW UP move. The problem can however be solved by the use of intonation. (We shall see later how the later developments of the model of analysis handle the exchange in other types of interaction).

(d) THE MOVE

This is the unit next in rank to the Exchange. It is described in terms of its function in the development of the discourse – that is: how the discourse begins, carries on and ends.

The categories used to describe Moves are-

- Initiation (I)
- Response (R)
- Follow-up/Feed Back (F)

You will now learn about the these units of the Move one by one.

INITIATION: To initiate may broadly mean any of the following:

- To make the first move
- To lead
- To begin
- To introduce an idea or aspect of an idea or concept for the first time.
- To express ones own will, mind, or thought.

In terms of discourse structuring and development, an Initiation is an utterance, which looks forward. This means that it requires another person to speak/act. It facilitates turns to speak and it causes other participants to take part in the Exchange. It is PREDICTIVE (i.e., forward looking). For instance, the teacher's Initiation predicts a Responding Move from the pupil.

The INITIATION MOVE in a classroom exchange consists typically of the following acts:

INITIATION: Directive, which looks forward to an Acknowledge (i.e., a verbal response) or
a React (a physical response)
Informative, which looks forward to an Acknowledge Response
Elicitation, which looks forward to a Reply

In all forms of spoken discourse there are "rules" about who speaks when (Schegloff and Sacks, 1973). Within the classroom, the teacher has the right to speak whenever he wants to, and the

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pupils contribute to the discourse when the teacher allows them to. A typical structure of a classroom Exchange is a teacher eliciting - followed by a pupil's reply. Most teachers have ways of selecting which pupil to reply. The ways include:

1. Teacher: **Nominates** a pupil to answer.
2. Pupils raise their hands or utter attention-calling words. This is known as **Bidding**. It is done in order for the pupil to be allowed to respond. Sometimes the teacher gives the children a **Cue** to bid, for example when he/she says: **"hands up"**.

Such, nominations are all subordinate elements of the teacher's Initiation Move. They are used as **Cues** of the structural units. Other subordinate elements accompanying the teacher's Initiation Move include - markers, meta-statements, conclusions, loops, etc.

RESPONSE: To respond means to take action after an Initiation. The action can be verbal or non-verbal. It means to react to an idea or ideas, which have already been expressed, by extending it/them. It can also be seen as meaning to conform to or even comply with the will expressed by others. It is to fulfill the prediction of the preceding move - i.e. the Initiation.

Thus the teacher's Initiation is usually followed by a RESPONSE MOVE as follows.

If it is a **DIRECTIVE** (giving a command or instructions) then the Response is a **REACT** or an **ACKNOWLEDGE**. A **REACT** is the performance of whatever action is required by the Directive. An **ACKNOWLEDGE** is a verbal or non-verbal signal which confirms that the pupil is listening and understanding. An Acknowledge is also an optional part of the response to a directive when it serves to let the teacher know that the pupil has heard. See the example below.

- [1] I T: ***Musa, I wonder if you could open the window.***
 R P: ***Yes / mm / sure / {goes to open the window}***

If the Initiation is an **INFORMATIVE** (giving information), then the Response is an **ACKNOWLEDGE**.

If the Initiation is an **ELICITATION** (asking a question, seeking information) then the Response is a **REPLY**, which can be a one word moodless utterance or a statement, as in the following example.

- [2] I A: Where did John go?
 R B: School (This is a moodless utterance)
 John went to school. (This is a statement)

FOLLOW-UP/FEED BACK: The Follow-up Move is also referred to as Feedback in the structure of the classroom discourse where it is used to evaluate - accept or comment on the pupil's response, as in the following example.

- [3] I T: ***Do you know what we mean by accent?*** - elicit
 R P: ***It is the way you talk*** - answer
 F T: ***The way we talk. This is a very broad comment.*** - evaluate
 I: ***Can you be more specific?*** - Request

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.....
As can be seen from the example [3] above, the function of the Follow-up Move in teaching Exchanges, is to let the pupil know how well she/he has performed. It usually occurs after the Response Move made by the pupil.

EXAMPLE S OF FOLLOW-UP IN OTHER TYPES OF DISCOURSE.

In the classroom it is typical to have:

- (a) The teacher asks a question. (INITIATION)
- (b) The pupil give a brief answer, then (RESPONSE)
- (c) The teacher closes the Exchange with an evaluation (FOLLOW-UP)
- (d) And then moves on to initiative another Exchange. (INITIATION)

In other types of discourse the Follow-up might be considered an additional element which is not structurally required or obligatory. Unlike in the case of the Response, which is predicted by the Initiation, the preceding segment of the discourse does not predict the Follow-up. But, nevertheless the Follow-up is related to the preceding segment. It may repeat, accept, reinforce, doubt, affirm, etc. it. But it does not depart from the preceding utterance nor does it add substantially to it.

Consider for example the Follow-ups in a Doctor - Patient discourse in the following example.

- [4] a) I D: *and this has been paining of late?*
R P: *well it's been the whole of last week.*
F D: *yes*

Yes, the Follow - up utterance, simply indicates that the Doctor has heard what is said. It could be omitted.

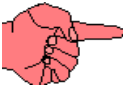
- [4] b) I D: *And what about the headache?*
How long have you had it?
R P: *I have had it a week last Wednesday*
F D: *A week last Wednesday.*

The Follow – up, D's last utterance, is simply repeating P's utterance.

- [4] c) I D: *but it's only the last three months that it's been making you feel ill.*
R P: *Ill with it, yes.*
F D: *Yes?*
F P: *Yes doctor.*

The last two utterances here are the Follow-ups and they are simply repeating what has been said.

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Note that as in example [4] (c), the Exchange structure proposed for the classroom discourse and other, allows, in theory, an infinite repetition of the follow-up (i.e., I R F F).

Also note that the notion **prediction** can help to distinguish the above units of the exchange as follows:

	PREDICTING	PREDICTED
1. INITIATION	+(YES)	- (NO)
2. RESPONSE	-(NO)	+ (YES)
3. FOLLOW-UP	-(NO)	- (NO)
4. (R/I)	+(YES)	+ (YES)

This means that an Initiation is predicting but not predicted; a Response is predicted but not predicting; while the Follow up is neither predicted nor predicting. The R/I, which is an utterance that is Response and an Initiation at the same time, is both predicted and predicting.



ACTIVITY

1. What does it mean to say that units of discourse can be arranged on Rank Scale?
2. Collect a short naturally occurring interaction between two people. Write it down in form of a conversation. And label/analyze it to show the exchanges and moves that are present in the conversation.
3. Are there any Focuses or Frames in your collected conversation. What are the uses of Focuses and Frames in an interaction?

(e) THE ACT

The unit at the lowest Rank of discourse structure is the Act. Although the Act almost corresponds to the grammatical unit clause, the two are very different in terms of how they are analyzed. The clause is analyzed in terms of grammar, which is concerned with formal properties of an item. The discourse Act is analyzed functionally. That is, the Act is concerned with functional properties - with what the speaker is using the linguistic item to do. Hence, each of the four sentence types the:

- Declaratives
- Interrogatives
- Imperatives (Moodless)

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- **Interjections / Exclamatives** may realize numerous discourse acts. And the acts do not necessarily depend on the sentence type. Many different acts occur in all forms of spoken discourse. The most common ones include:
 1. Elicitation
 2. Directive
 3. Informative

Normally, either, the Elicitation, the Directive or, the Informative constitutes the head – i.e., most important part, of the Initiating Move.

Elicitation - This is an act that serves/functions to request a linguistic response. (e.g. asks a question). However, the response may be a non-verbal surrogate / substitute such as a nod or raised hand.

Directive - This is an act that functions to request a non - linguistic response, one involving a physical action, such as, standing up or any other physical action.

Informative – This is an act whose function is to pass on ideas, facts, opinions, and the like to the addressee. That is, it gives information. The appropriate response to an Informative act is an acknowledgement that one is listening.

Elicitation, Directives and Informative are very frequently realized by Interrogative, Imperative and Declarative sentences, respectively. But this is not always the case, as in Indirect Speech Acts (See Lesson 7, section 7.7). An Indirect Speech act is the act performed when you use, say, a question to, for example give a directive, as in the utterance: “Can you pass me the salt?” to which the speaker can only rightfully respond by passing the salt.

Other acts performed in the discourse moves I R F (Initiation, Response, Follow-up) include the following which are listed along with a specification of the function each plays and exemplification of each.

Discourse acts performed within the moves include:

<u>CATEGORY:</u> <u>OF ACT</u>	<u>FUNCTION</u>	<u>EXAMPLES OF</u> <u>EXPRESSIONS</u>
Marker:	mark boundaries in the discourse	well, ok now good, right
Elicitation:	request linguistic response	questions
Directive	request a non-Linguistic response	commands
Informative:	provide information	statements
Prompt:	reinforce a directive	go on, come on,

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	informative or elicitation	hurry up
Acknowledge:	show that initiation has been understood or that the react is intended.	yes, ok. yeah, other expressions
Reply:	provide a linguistic response appropriate to the elicitation	statement question
	question	moodless. non-verbal act e.g. 'nod'
React:	provide the appropriate non-linguistic response defined by the preceding Directive	doing something physical
Comment:	exemplify, expand, justify, provide additional information	
Accept	Indicate that the listener has heard Or seen and that the information reply or react is appropriate.	yes, good, fine, statement
Evaluate	to evaluate the response	statement, tag Questions, words, phrases
Meta - Statement	structures the discourse	statement with future time.
Conclusion	summarizes what the preceding chunk of discourse was about	anaphoric statement, so,---then..., thus, hence.



7.3.3 MORE ABOUT THE EXCHANGE

The above categories were quite applicable in the analysis of classroom discourse. However for the Analysis of Everyday Conversation more needs to be investigated about the structure of the exchange. For instance, the exchange structure proposed for the analysis of classroom discourse was:

$E = I R F_n$

(i.e., This is to say that an Exchange consists of Initiation, Response and a number of Follow up Moves)

But, after examining other kinds of data it was found that this rule is not adequate. It cannot handle other data, particularly those with elicitations as in B's first utterance in the following example.

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- [5] I A: *Can anyone tell me what this means?*
 R/1 B: *Does it mean danger men at work.?*
 R A: *Yeah.*
 F B: *I see.*

Here in [5] we have $\mathbf{R}/\mathbf{I}$ following $\mathbf{I}$ instead of $\mathbf{R}$. following $\mathbf{I}$.

R/I maintains the prediction characteristics of both Response and Initiation. It functions as a Response with respect to the preceding element and as an Initiation with respect to the following element. It has a dual function of Response/Initiation, thus **R/I**.

The other feature of the structure of the exchange which was established after examining everyday conversation is that the follow-up (F) move is optional and we can easily have Exchanges consisting of only two moves, an Initiation (I) and a Response (R), hence:

$$E = IR.$$

Thus the structure of the shortest exchange was stated as:

E = I.R. (Initiation + Response), as in

[6] 1 A: *Alice has gone to school.*
R B: *Yes.*

And the structure of the longest exchange was stated as:

E = I R/I R Fn, as in:

- [7] I A: *I need something to drink.*
 R/I B: *Will you have a cold or hot drink?*
 R A: *Cold*
 F B: *Ok*
 F A: *Thanks*

Hence the general rule for the structure of an Exchange could be stated as:

$$E = I (R/1) \quad R (F_n)$$

This rule would generate the shortest discourse Exchanges like:

- [8] I A: *How are you*
R B: *Fine* (Of the Rule: $\mathbf{E} = \mathbf{I} \mathbf{R}$)

It would also generate the longest Exchange like in E1 in [9] below:

- [9] E1 I A: *Where's the type writer?* (An Elicit)
R/1 B: *Is it in the cupboard?* (Another Elicit)
R A: **No** (A Reply)

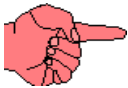
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F B: *Oh dear* (An Acknowledge)
F A: *Yeah* (Another Acknowledge)

E2 I A: *I guess I'll have to use the computer* (An Inform)
 R B: *Yeah*

Where the first Exchange (E1) is generated by the rule:

E = I R / I R F n and **E2** by the rule: **E = I R**



Note

The above given structure roughly categories the components of an exchange. However, we must accept that a speaker can do anything he/she likes at any time. At the same time, we must recognize that what the speaker does will be classified as a contribution to the discourse in the light of whatever structural predictions the previous contributions may have set up. That is, the structure offered for the Exchange is very much an interpretive template which makes predictions about what a speaker may do next provided he/she chooses to stay within the same exchange. But, the Exchange boundary is not very objectively definable.

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ACTIVITY

1. Analyze the following service encounter discourse to show its structural parts using the Birmingham School units of spoken discourse. The first exchange of the interaction has been analyzed for you as an example.

<u>EXCHANGE & MOVE</u>	<u>UTTERANCE</u>	<u>ACT</u>
E1	I	A: Hi. May I help you? {Greeting; Offer}
	R	B: Yes Please. {Accept}
		Could I have something for a cough?
		I think I am getting a cold.
		A: Well, I suggest a box of these cough drops
		B: Thank you.
		What do you suggest for dry skin?
		A: Try some of this new lotion. It's very good.
		B: Ok.
		B: and one more thing.
		My husband has no energy these days.
		Can you suggest anything?
	A:	He should try some of these multivitamins.
		They are excellent.
		B: Great! May I have three large bottles please?
	A:	;...

2. Are there any Frames / Focuses used in the discourse?
3. How many Transactions are in this interaction and how many Exchanges in each of the Transactions?

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7.4 SUMMARY

Since onset of rigorous studies of discourse in the early 70s, there have been a number of approaches to the analysis of the structure of discourse. The approaches have been coming from different disciplines and subject backgrounds including: Linguistics, Philosophy, Sociology, and Cultural studies. The approaches from Linguistics are usually referred to as Discourse Analysis if they focus on spoken discourse and Text Linguistics if they focus on written discourse. Studies of discourse originating from Philosophy gave rise to the Speech Act Theory; those from sociology are known as conversational analysis; those from Cultural studies are associated with Ethnography of Speaking. You learned about Conversational Analysis and Ethnography of Speaking in Lesson 5; about Discourse Analysis in this Lesson you are now about to learn something brief about Speech Act Theory in Lesson 7 that follows.

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BY OCHIENG BRIAN MASJID

LECTURE 8

THE ROLE OF SPEECH ACT THEORY IN DISCOURSE ANALYSIS



8.1 INTRODUCTION

In Lecture 7 you learned that in Discourse Analysis language is analyzed by looking at the function it does in human interaction. When you look at a sentence or an utterance that has occurred as people talk with one another, you ask not what the sentence is formed of, but what the sentence has been used for. That is, what does the sentence or utterance do in its place of occurrence in that particular discourse? When you ask such questions, you want to know the act that has been performed by the linguistic occurrence. This line of investigating language was originally the concern of scholars from the field of Linguistic philosophy. Their descriptions of language, which tried to give account of the actions performed by language, were referred to as **Speech Act Theory**. In this chapter you will learn about how Speech Act Theory has contributed to the analysis of discourse.



8.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Explain what is meant by saying that we use language to do things.
- Classify any language utterance/sentence that you come across in daily use into the categories it belongs to in terms of Speech Act theory.
- Distinguish between and illustrate each of the three categories of locution according to Austin.
- Outline the distinguishing features of the five categories of Illocutionary Acts according to Searle.
- Illustrate the role of felicity conditions in speech act analysis

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8.3 INTRODUCING SPEECH ACT THEORY

Speech Act Analysis was an area of focus for scholars in the field of Linguistic Philosophy, or Philosophers of Language. The main concern of these scholars was to understand the nature of thought, its logic, and how it is communicated. To achieve this aim, the philosophers of language studied and analyzed the way natural human language conveys thought/meaning. That is, how language is used to communicate thought from the producer to the interpreter. In human communication, thought is converted to/coded into language, which is then sent to the receiver who in turn interprets its meaning. The Linguistic Philosophers investigated what meaning is interpreted by the receiver of language, in order to have some idea of the thought held by the producer of the language.

Since language, which carries the message, occurs in the form of utterances (if speech) and sentences (if writing), the philosophers of language believed that to some extent, it is possible to know what goes on in people's minds, by studying the utterances/sentences, which people utter or write to one another. So they concerned themselves with studying sentences to identify what people use sentences/utterances to do.

They proceeded from a basic assumption that it must be possible to specify rules relating sentences/utterances to the actions performed by the participants when language occurs in context. The rules for the identification of the actions are formulated informally after considering the context of the sentence or utterance. For instance, an utterance can be identified as performing the act of inviting - i.e., INVITATION - if the speaker proposes that the hearer does something which is assumed he/she likes doing, or is pleasing to do, and which involves some effort on the part of the speaker. According to such informal rules, utterances may be labeled as performing acts such as:

- Informing
- Requesting
- Inviting
- Etc
- Questioning/Inquiring
- Commanding

The assumptions held by the philosophers of language, together with their descriptive categories proposed for the analysis of the actions performed by the utterances, constitute what is known as **Speech Act Theory**. The philosophers of language who are well known in this line of language study are:

(i) The British Philosopher, J. L. Austin (1911-1960s) whose studies of meaning gave rise to the notion of "How to do things with words" (Austin 1962). He was the first to draw attention to utterances as part of interpersonal communication. He pointed out that many utterances do not communicate information but are equivalent to actions. For instance, when someone says "I apologize....or. I promise..... the utterance conveys a new psychological or social reality. An apology/a promise takes place.

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John Searle (1969, 1975), who further developed Austin's ideas of how to do things with words by adding new ideas to the original ones and presenting them in a more systematic manner.

The ideas advanced by these two philosophers have since been advanced and used in various ways by other scholars interested in speech act analysis.



8.4 STARTING POINT OF SPEECH ACT ANALYSIS/THEORY

In the 1930s Philosophers of Language, operating within the logical positivism frame of mind, maintained the central tenet that: All sentences/utterance that occur in a language must be verified for their truth value. That is, a sentence must be either TRUE or FALSE. That, unless a sentence can be verified for its truth or falsity, it was strictly speaking, MEANINGLESS.



From your own point of view, how realistic was this belief?

The belief that all sentences/utterances that occur in everyday language used for communication must be either true or false may not be very realistic. This is because in everyday communication we utter many sentences that do not report directly on facts or states of affairs but they are still meaningful to our lives. For example, when we produce ethical, aesthetic, and literary discourses, like in the use of proverbs, poems, prayers, preaching, the utterances convey our opinions beliefs or feelings. These may not be true or even false but they are meaningful in our lives. Consider for example the following utterances.

- [1] *Today is your only chance for the Lord's salvation.*
- [2] *Proverbs are the palm oil with which words are eaten.*

None of the propositions in these sentence, i.e., that: today is the only chance; Proverbs are oils; Words are eaten - can not be said to be either true or false. But this does not make them meaningless. They still convey some meaning to their users.

It was during the same period when Austin (1953-62), a scholar in the same field of Linguistic Philosophy started to study more carefully the utterances/sentences that people produced as they communicated. He discovered that not all utterances/sentences that occurred in linguistic communication could be verified by truth conditions and he disagreed with the logical positivists who were trying to insist that truth conditions were central to language understanding. Austin recognized that the utterances/sentences of language could be placed into two categories:

Those that have truth value,	known as	CONSTATIVES
Those that do not have truth value,	known as	PERFORMATIVES

The **Constatives** are utterances/sentences that report states of affairs. They are statements of facts, such as,

- [3] *The days are becoming warmer and warmer.*

The **Performatives** are utterances/ sentences in which the saying and the doing are one and the same thing. In realizing Performatives, as you speak you are not simply saying, you are actually doing something. Consider for example the following extract used by Clothier (2004).

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being true or false. When uttered the hearer can say that it true or that it is false. Examples of Constatives are as follows:

- [1] *The oldest man in our village is bald.*
- [2] *The president of the skies will attend our graduation ceremony this year.*
- [3] *Father Christmas will be born on 30th December 2005.*
- [4] *Kenyatta University is located on the outskirts of Nairobi City.*

Performatives are sentences in which the saying of the words constitute an action, or the performing of an act. They are units of language used to do things. Examples of Performatives are:

- [1] *I bet you five shillings, the real thief will be acquitted.* (action of BETTING)
- [2] *I baptize you in the name of the Father, Son and Holly Ghost.* (action of BAPTIZING)”
- [3] *I declare this gathering dissolved.* (action of DISSOLVING A GATHERING)
- [4] *I disown you from today onwards.* (action of DISOWNING)”
- [5] *I resign.* (action of RESIGNING)

These are the utterances in which the mentioning/saying/producing of the words and doing the action are one and the same thing.

Although, they may be Declarative in form, they cannot be tested for truth value. The kind of conditions required for the meanings of Performatives to be acceptable are not truth conditions but rather conditions of appropriateness. Such conditions were named by Austin as, Felicity Conditions. Felicity Conditions are external conditions to be fulfilled before the Performative utterance can be accepted as performing the act in question. For example, you cannot have an occurrence as follows:

- [6] *A: By the powers vested on me, I now declare this congregation dissolved.*
**B: No sir, that is not true.*



Note that the Felicity Conditions established by Austin were of two types:

(i) **Ritualistic Constraints**, involving social and cultural events. That is, there must be a ritual going on for the utterance to be seen as performing the action. For example, the utterance:

- [1] ... *I baptize you John....,*

produced by a pastor to a Christian child or adult at a church gathering at some acceptable venue, will be seen as performing the act of **Baptism**.

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For it to perform the act of sentencing the utterance:

[2] *I sentence you to life imprisonment.*

must be said by a judge in court.

(ii) **Acceptable Conventional Procedure**, involving the following of a procedure. A procedure must be followed for the act to be acceptable. The procedure must include the uttering of certain words by certain person in a certain setting; place and time. For instance:

[3] *I sentence you to death.*

performs the action/function of sentencing a convict to death. But this function is only performed (within certain legal systems) by this utterance when uttered by someone with the authority, and in a country where there is a death penalty to the convict. And it must be spoken at the right time (end of trial) and the right place (in court).

In addition to having a clear Declarative form, the Performatives were seen to have well recognized syntactic/grammatical characteristics. For instance, a Performative sentence will:

- Have a Performative Verb (e.g., promise, warn, name, baptize, declare, decree, announce). The performative verb names the speech act
- Occurs in the simple present tense. (e.g., I **name** the ship)
- It has a First-person pronoun subject (e.g. I, we)
- It has the possibility of adding the Adverb '**hereby**', as in, "I hereby declare the congregation dissolved"; I **hereby** resign"



8.5 HOW SPEECH ACT THEORY DEVELOPED

As time went by, later on, the philosophers of language, led by Austin realized that the assumption that all language can simply and neatly be classified into the two categories: Constatives and Performatives, was highly mistaken. This was because, when one looked at language which occurred in use, it was very difficult for one to distinguish the two types, or to describe them in distinctive terms. They could not be separated in formal or systematic ways.

Further scrutiny of CONSTATIVES revealed the following:

Some of the Constatives that occur in the form of Declaratives are not intended to record or impart information about facts. In fact, some are nonsensical in spite their exceptionally correct grammatical form. Consider once again, the examples given above and repeated here below:

[1] The president of the skies will attend our graduation ceremony this year.

[2] Father Christmas will be born on 30th December 2006.

These statements are nonsensical. They do not have any truth value, a necessary property of statements or Declaratives. They are simply coined structures for educational purposes.

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Other statements that may occur are intended to solely or partly evoke emotion or the influence the hearer in a special way. For instance:

- [3] I am sick and tired of going for water from the river.
- [4] I am dying.
- [5] You are weak.
- [6] You are beautiful.

Each of this could be said not to mean the particular states of affairs, but to evoke some kind of response or emotion from the hearer.



What kind of emotion would one evoke by each of the utterances [3] to [6] above?

In trying to describe Performatives in distinctive terms, Austin discovered even more difficult problems.

(i) Firstly, the physical form of Performatives shows that they are Declaratives or statements (i.e., they just look like Constatives). However they do not report facts, and they cannot be tested for truth value.

(ii) Secondly, the exemplary syntactic characteristics stated above (i.e., the presence of performative verb; occurring in the simple present tense; having a first-person pronoun subject; and the possibility of adding the Adverb *hereby*) are not always needed for an utterance to serve as a Performative.

(iii) Thirdly, one need not have to look for the ritualistic constraints and conventional procedures- i.e., felicity conditions every time, in order to identify as appropriate all the possible Performative utterances. Austin discovered that, there are many more kinds of utterances in which the uttering of the words constitute the performing of an act: many more with neither the exemplary syntactic characteristics nor the felicity conditions. For example:

{	I am Sorry. (A DECLARATIVE) I hereby apologize.	}	may each perform the act of apologizing
---	--	---	---

{	I will do it. (A DECLARATIVE) I hereby promise to do it.	}	may each perform the act of promising
---	---	---	---

{	Won't the dog bite you? (AN INTERROGATIVE) I hereby warn you that the dog will bite you. Be careful with that dog. (AN IMPERATIVE) The tea is very hot. (A DECLARATIVE) Don't take that tea. (AN IMPERATIVE)	}	may each perform the act of warning
---	--	---	--

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$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{Stand up! (AN IMPERATIVE)} \\ \text{I hereby order you to stand up.} \end{array} \right\}$	may each perform the act of ordering.
--	--

In fact the Performatives that are identified with the felicity conditions and the specific syntactic feature are quite rare in real language use.

Austin then concluded that there is no need of saying that Performative utterances are this or that. There are no rule governed conventions restricting the use of such Performatives. Anyone can make a promise to anyone in any place at any time. And you don not need to use a Performative verb to perform an action. Even statements such as '*the tea is hot*', which have no Performative word used at all, can perform an act such as '*warning*'. Hence the distinction between Constatives and Performatives was found to hold no water.



8.5.1 HOW AUSTIN PROCEEDED WITH THE DEVELOPMENT OF SPEECH ACT THEORY

The above outlined realizations lead Austin and the other philosophers of language to look at the actions performed by utterances from a broader perspective. That the initial two categories, of language use namely:

- (i) Talking about the world - CONSTATIVES
 - (ii) Doing something in the world - PERFORMATIVES
- were unrealistic.

Austin (1962) therefore asserts that it is more realistic to look at language form and function in more general terms. He was lead to the realization that: **ALL utterances perform actions.**

In other words, when one produces an utterance, one performs an act. This means that in terms of functions, ALL utterances are Performatives. That is, they all relate to the behaviour of the speaker and hearer. If ALL utterances perform acts then what needs to be analyzed is:

- (i) What is the range of possible functions that an utterance may perform?
- (ii) How can a function be interpreted in a particular situation?

Austin proceeded to address part of the first of these questions, as you will see in section 7.4.11 below, while, the remaining part of the first question together with the second question were later addressed by Searle (See section 7.4.2. below)

8.5.1.1 AUSTIN'S THREE ACTS

Having asserted that all utterances are Performatives, and that: 'to say something is to do something'. Austin then considers the sense in which 'to say something is to do something' and concludes that: '**Whenever one produces an utterance one performs three acts simultaneously**':

- 1 - Locutionary Act
- 2 - Illocutionary Act , and

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3 - Perlocutionary Act.

1) **Locutionary Act:** This is the act **OF** actually producing or saying or uttering the words. The words produced or uttered must have a particular literal sense and reference. They must be meaningful semantically. The following utterances [1] and [2] are meaningful English sentences:

[1] ***The tea is very hot.***

[2] ***Shoot her!***

Each of the words or expressions in the utterances above have a particular literal sense. That is, each has semantic meaningful and can be described semantically. The production of the utterances amounts to the fact that a communicative act has taken place. Someone has said something to another as opposed to just the production of 'meaningless' noise.

2) **Illocutionary Act:** This is the act performed **IN** saying something. The act identified by the explicit Performative Verb. It is the force of what is said, where '**saying**' equals '**doing**'. It concerns actions such as: informing, asking, answering, betting, promising, resigning, and, warning as in,

[3] ***The dog will bite you.***

which can be rephrased as:

[4] **I warn you that 'the dog will bite you'**

Or: **ordering, urging**, as in: [5] ***Shoot her!***

An action that can be paraphrased in a reported speech such as:

[6] ***He ordered/urged her to shoot him.***

The utterance in example [3] above has the illocutionary force (i.e., the force of the illocution) of warning, while example [5] has the force of ordering or urging depending on the context of situation.

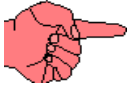
3) **Perlocutionary Act:** This is the act performed **BY MEANS OF or AS A RESULT OF** saying something. It is the effect of the utterance on the addressee. For example, the addressee may be amused, persuaded, warned as a consequence. The bringing about of such a consequence is the Perlocutionary act. For example:

[7] Now that they **urged** me to invite my neighbours to the party,

[8] I was **persuaded** to do so.

In these examples urged is the illocutionary act and persuaded is the Perlocutionary act.

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Note

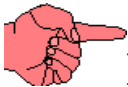
- The **Illocutionary force** of an utterance and its Perlocutionary effect may not coincide. E.g., If warned against a particular course of action, you may or may not heed the warning.
- There are thousands of possible Illocutionary acts and several attempts have been made to classify them in to a smaller number of types. One influential approach sets up 5 basic types (After J. R. Searle (1975) as seen below



8.5.2 IMPORTANCE OF ANALYZING ILLOCUTIONS

Austin emphasized the need to focus descriptions of speech acts on the second of the three categories: the Illocutionary Act. He argued that the LOCUTIONARY ACT belongs to the traditional territory of truth-based semantics. The meanings of the uttered words can be studied under semantics. The PERLOCUTIONARY ACT on the other hand belongs, strictly speaking, beyond the investigation of language and meaning, since it deals with the effect of, or result of an utterance. Whether my words (locutionary act) of request (illocutionary act) persuade (perlocutionary act) someone to lend me fifty shillings depends on factors, which may be (psychological, social, or physical) beyond my control, and it is only partly a matter of what I said. The ILLOCUTION occupies the middle ground between the two ends. This is the ground of meaning in context, which is the concern of Discourse Analysis. It is the domain of language used to communicate with other people.

After these explorations Austin was not able to continue his description of speech acts. The work was taken over by Austin's student: John Searle (1969,75) who then systematized the speech act theory categories of analyzing speech acts.



Note

The verbs used to describe illocutions such as claim, promise, beg, invite, thank, request, declare, urge, etc, are generally know as the **Performative Verbs**.

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ACTIVITY

1. What do you understand by the idea of ‘how to do things with words’?
2. Name and define each of the Categories finally established by Austin for the description of speech acts.
3. Study the following extract from *Alice in Wonderland* and assign each of the sentences to the more appropriate of the two initial categories of speech acts as designed by Austin and the early philosophers of language.

A DISCOURSE EXTRACT

Alice was very curious so she walked towards them and asked timidly: “Excuse me, Why are you painting those roses red?” The gardeners looked sad and quite embarrassed. “Well”, answered two in a low voice. “This should be a red - rose tree but...” “Well you see, we put in a white rose tree instead” said Five. “It was a mistake”, added Seven. (From Alice In Wonderland)

8.5.3 SEARLE’S (1969; 1975) CATEGORIES OF SPEECH ACTS

Searle was the other philosopher of language who developed Speech Act Theory further. Among other things he concentrated on the category of Illocutionary act - the act performed in saying something, for instance, advising as in:

[1] You should drop that matter.

Which can be reported as:

[2] He **advised** me to drop the matter.

Searle acknowledged that there are thousands of illocutions that may be performed using sentences/utterances of a language. Moreover, even just one utterance is capable of performing many different illocutionary actions. One could therefore analyze, for example (i) What is the range of possible functions that an utterance may perform. If all utterances perform a range of actions, then the next question is (ii) How can a particular function be interpreted in a particular situation? This entails looking at the context of situation of the discourse the utterance is part of, with a particular reference to the felicity conditions.

Searle, thus studied the conditions that prevail for the performing of the illocutionary acts to be realized. He identified the following categories of conditions, which he considered rules.

- (a). Regulatory Rules
- (b). Constitutive Rules

Searle (1969:33-35) distinguishes these rules as follows.

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Regulatory Rules are conditions regulating the occurrence of certain kinds of behaviour. The behaviour exists with or without the regulatory rule. For example: there are many rules of etiquette regulating inter-personal relationships. But the people may still behave with or without following the rules. For instance, in a certain social circle it may be a rule of etiquette that invitations to parties must be sent out at least two weeks in advance. But one may still send his/hers later. **Constitutive Rules**, on the other hand, do not merely regulate, they create or define new forms of behaviour. **Regulatory rules** regulate a pre-existing activity, an activity whose existence is logically independent of the rules. **Constitutive rules** constitute the activity. They form the activity, which in turn cannot be there without them. **Regulatory rules** characteristically take the form of, or can be paraphrased as imperatives, e.g.,

- 'When cutting food hold the knife in the right hand.' or
- 'Officers must wear ties at dinner.'

Constitutive rules take quite different forms, e.g.,

- 'A check mate is made when the king is attacked in such a way that no move will leave it unattacked'

The **Regulatory rules** are conditions on the occurrence of certain forms of behaviour. Thus the utterances that we produce should occur in a regular manner - obeying the societal Regulatory rules, but more importantly, for you to interpret the action they are performing, you must look keenly at the Constitutive rules: What forms them? Constitutive Rules are explained below.

Constitutive Rules

These are rules that define the form of the act, or the behaviour itself. In speech the constitutive rules are those which control the ways in which an utterance of a given form is heard as realizing a given illocutionary act. That is, they explain what functional and formal parts of the utterance make it be interpreted as performing a particular act. And every act may have a different set of rules just meant for it.

Studying certain acts including the act of PROMISING, Searle suggested the following categories of Constitutive rules:

(i) Propositional Content Rules

These are the rules that specify the kind of meaning expressed by the propositional part of the utterance, interpreted literally. For example, a promise must refer to some future act by the speaker. For example: [1] ***I will give you the money this month end.***

(ii) Preparatory Rules.

These are the rules that specify conditions that are essential for the performance of the speech act. For example, for an act of thanking the speaker must be aware that the addressee has done something of benefit to the speaker. For example: [2] You are so kind.

(iii) Sincerity Rules.

These are rules that specify conditions that must obtain if the speech act is to be performed sincerely, genuinely. For example, for an apology to be sincere, the speaker must be sorry for what he/she has done.

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(iv) Essential Rules

These specify what the speech act must conventionally count as. For instance, the essential rule for a warning is that it counts as an undertaking that some future event is not in the addressee's interest.



What are constitutive rules? Think of and state any Constitutive rule that you know about.

Searle argued that on the basis of these four Constitutive rule types, thousand of illocutionary acts may be recognized/identified in human use of language. To describe the thousands of acts in a systematic but manageable way he chose to study them not singly but in categories.

He thus grouped the Illocutionary Acts into FIVE 5 broad categories namely:

- i Representatives
- ii Directives
- iii Comissives
- iv Expressives
- v Declaratives

i) REPRESENTATIVES / ASSERTIVES

The Representatives are also known as Assertives. A representative is an utterance, which tells people about things or how things are in the world. In other words, in a representative, the speaker fits his words to the world. The speaker here makes a statement about something. This statement can be judged for truth value. The utterances here perform acts such as stating, claiming, reporting, announcing, affirming, believing, concluding, denying, etc. The speaker here is committed, in varying degrees, to the truth of the proposition he is making. A Representative incorporates the speaker's belief that something is. Examples of Representative utterances are:

- [1] The university admits both young men and women.
- [2] The country experienced a long period of drought last year.

These statements can be tested for truth value - i.e., they can be said to be true or false.

ii) DIRECTIVES

These are the utterances made by a speaker in an attempt to get the hearer to do something. Here the speaker wants to achieve a change, or an effect in the world. They include when a request is being made that someone will do or stop doing something. They concern where we try to get people or hearers to do things or when a request is being made that someone other than the speaker will do or stop doing something. Examples of Directives include.

- [3] Will you shut the door?
- [4] I order you to stand up/Stand up!

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Included in this category are such acts as: ordering, requesting, demanding, begging asking, challenging, commanding, and insisting. Elicitations such as ‘What time is it?’ are Directives in that they require the speaker to give information.

iii) COMMISSIVES

These are like Directives. They are concerned with altering the world to match the words spoken, but this time the point is to commit the speaker him/herself to acting in the future. They necessarily involve INTENTIONS, where an utterance serves to commit the speaker to doing something in the future. Examples of Commissives include.

[5] May be I can plant the maize tomorrow.

[6] I will go to town this afternoon

Commissives include utterances, which perform the speech act functions like promising, offering, swearing, pledging, vowing, etc, to do something in the future. The speaker is committed in varying degrees to a certain course of action.

iv) EXPRESSIVES

These include utterances, which have an expressive function. They express some psychological state of mind, or feeling of the speaker/writer. They concern the function of language where we express/utter/present our feelings and attitudes about a state of affairs, or an object or person. They involve statements of joy, disappointment, gratitude, likes, dislikes, complements, congratulations, complaints, disappointment, regrets, apologies, hospitality, and others. Examples of utterances belonging to the expressive category of illocutionary act and the specific act each may perform is listed below.

[7] a) What a great job you have done?	–	CONGRATULATING
b) Oh my! That’s terrible.	-	COMPLAINING
c) I am sorry.	-	APOLOGIZING
d) Thanks!	-	THANKING
e) I’m so happy you came	-	APPRECIATING
f) What, I didn’t expect it	-	EXPRESING SURPRISE
g) You are welcome to this place	-	WELCOMING
h) Please feel most welcome	-	WELCOMING

v) DECLARATIONS

These are the utterances in which saying the words and doing the action are one and the same thing. In producing these utterances the world is immediately altered. The utterances belonging here include many of those earlier categorized by Austin as Performatives, as in: naming a ship, sentencing, dismissing, etc. They are the ones, which typically require an extra-linguistic institution, which provides the rules for their use and interpretation, for instance, a court, church, committee, institution of learning, etc. When we use such declarations we bring about change through our utterances as we make them. There is in them correspondence between the propositional content and reality. The propositional content is the meaning expressed. The reality is the, say: baptizing, sentencing a thief to life imprisonment, dissolving a congregation, etc.

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ACTIVITY

1. Name and define each of the 5 Categories established by Searle for the description of Illocutionary acts.
2. Compare and contrast Commissives and Directives
3. Study the following extract and assign each of the sentences to the most appropriate of the Searle's five categories. Can you see any overlapping of utterances with regard to which category they fall under?

EXTRACT FOR QUESTION 2

Congratulations! You have now gone through every stage of the writing process. Give yourself several pats on the back. Also take a much deserved rest as you wait for the next article on writing strategies. I will make available to you the next article in a week's time.

BY OCHIENG BRIAN MASJID



8.6 THE ROLE OF SPEECH ACT THEORY IN DISCOURSE ANALYSIS

Searle argued that on the basis of the Constitutive as well as regulatory rules, different speech acts can easily be distinguished in the utterances which occur as people use language. That is to say that, with the knowledge of the rules and the five categories of speech acts, one can determine the functions of utterances in a discourse. Also discourse structure can be stated in functional terms.

However, more recent work in Discourse Analysis indicate that the establishment of discrete categories of speech acts and interpreting the act being performed in a particular utterance is still problematic. Searle's categories and conditions can only help to a certain extent. For example, there are problems when utterances occur in form of **Indirect Speech Acts**.

Indirect Speech Acts occur where the grammatical categories of MOOD of the sentences do not serve the normally expected functions (See Coulthard 1985 for more detail). The grammatical categories of mood are:

- Declaratives, which are grammatically designed to make statements
- Interrogatives, which are grammatically designed to ask questions
- Imperatives, which are grammatically designed to give commands or directives and,

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- Exclamatives, which are grammatically designed to express feelings,

as in the following examples:

MOOD (Form)

- [1] Did you close the door? -
- [2] Close the door (please) -
- [3] She closed the door -

Function

- Question
- Command (Request)
- Statement

When utterance with question forms such as: Did you ..., Are you ..., Can you ..., are used to ask questions, they are considered or described as Direct Speech Acts because there is a one to one correspondence between form and function. A problem, however, arises when the utterances occurring in any one of the above forms (i.e., in the form of Declarative, or, Interrogative, or Imperative or Exclamative, are NOT actually performing the grammatically expected function of statement, question, and directive respectively, as in the following examples:

as in the following examples:

- [1] ***Can you pass the salt?*** – (an INTERROGATIVE form but functioning not as a QUESTION seeking verbal response, but a request or DIRECTIVE requiring physical action).

- [2] ***You left the door open.*** – (a DECLARATIVE form but function not as statement of fact, but as an order or a DIRECTIVE that the hearer should go back and close the door.

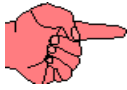
- [3] ***Will you stand up?*** - (an INTERROGATIVE form but functioning not as a QUESTION seeking verbal response, but a DIRECTIVE requiring physical action).

Many examples of indirect speech acts like the above occur in everyday talk. That is, although some speech acts directly address the listener, the majority of acts in everyday conversation are indirect. There are numerous ways of asking one to perform an action. The most direct way is to use an imperative – e.g., “shut the door”-, but you can see that this would be inappropriate in many everyday situations. It appears abrupt and rude. Alternatives that do the same function tend to stress the hearer’s ability or desire to perform the action, or the speaker’s reason for requiring the action done, as in the following examples:

- [4] I’d be grateful if you’d shut the door.
- [5] Could you shut the door.
- [6] Would you mind shutting the door.
- [7] It’d help to have the door shut
- [8] It’s getting cold here.

Any of these could, in the right situation, function as a request for action from the hearer, although none has the clear form of an Imperative.

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Note

That such indirect speech acts are always open to the hearer to misunderstand either accidentally or deliberately:

TEACHER: *Amari, there is some chalk on the floor.*

AMARI: *Yes, there is Sir.*

TEACHER: *Well, pick it up, then!*

The existence of indirect speech acts show that there is no one to one correlation between language form and function/speech acts. So they help us interpret the actions of the occurring utterances we need the felicity conditions or regulative and constitutive rules. So, for example, for an utterance like:

[1] Can you stand up?

To know that [1] is an order for the hearer to stand up, we must check if it obeys the following constitutive conditions:

- PROPOSITIONAL CONTENT - There is a sentence with the right grammatical configurations.
- PREPARATORY RULE - The receiver has the ability to do the action; also
- the sender has the right to tell the receiver
to do the action.
- ESSENTIAL RULE - There is need for the hearer to stand up
- SINCERITY RULE - The sender believes the action should be done

Thus, in spite of Indirect speech acts, the functions of utterances occurring in a discourse can be assigned according to these Searle's five categories, with the help of felicity conditions, along with the other features of context, which provide the knowledge, that participants need to interpret the discourse.

Hence we can say that the major contribution of Speech act theory to Discourse Analysis was to draw attention of language study to the following ideas:

- That we actually use language not only to say things, but to do things, to perform actions.
- That the utterances or sentences that we produce as part of our interpersonal communication perform actions.
- That when the actions performed by the utterances/sentences occur, certain effects are realized in the hearer.
- Therefore utterances, say things, do things and have effects on the participants.

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Speech act Theory helped to establish that when the utterances are considered in context – within felicity conditions, and constitutive rules – their functions are interpreted. They also came up with categories of acts and conditions of interpretation which would make it possible to interpret and describe discourse structural segments in functional terms – i.e., what the sentences/utterances used in human interaction are doing. This was on the basis of their basic assumption that a classification of illocutionary acts is a classification of the basic things we can do with language.

Hence Speech act theory has provided Discourse analysis with certain means/some of tools of description to use in understanding and analyzing the structure of exchanges in linguistic communication.



8.7 SUMMARY

To conclude we can say that speech act analysis showed that sentences/ utterances occurring in human interaction may perform thousands of possible acts, i.e., Illocutionary acts. Several attempts have been made to classify them into a smaller number of types. One influential approach , J R. Searle (1975) set up the following five categories:

REPRESENTATIVES, where the speaker states a proposition affirming or denying, reporting, concluding, etc, a state of affairs in the world.

DIRECTIVES, where the speaker tries to get the hearer to do something by asking Commanding, insisting, requesting, directing, etc

COMMISSIVES, where the speaker is committing him/herself to a certain course of action by guaranteeing, promising, pledging, vowing, swearing offering etc

EXPRESSIVES, where the speaker expresses an attitude about a state of affairs, as in Apologizing, deploring, thanking, congratulating, etc. and,

DECLARATIONS, where, the speaker alters the external status or condition of an object or situation by declaring, resigning, baptizing firing etc.

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ACTIVITY

1. Study the following discourse occurrence and use it to answer the questions below it.

YES! REWARDS CUSTOMERS

.... “Our Good News Day is a way of showing appreciation for our subscribers and to thank them regularly for their continued loyalty. We keep our promise to offer additional value for their money and we will continue to do so.” This month’s good news day was the Yes! play & win which had an overwhelming response. To enable Yes! subscribers to benefit more from this popular promotion, the promotion has been extended to the month of September with another 120,000/- jackpot to be split among up to four lucky winners.

(Adopted from Daily Nation, Friday, August 29, 2003)

1. Now List each of the sentences occurring in the discourse and indicate, against each one, the Searle’s category of Speech Acts to which it belongs.
2. J.L. Austin (1962) says that an utterance performs THREE different ACTS at the same time. How is this possible? Use examples from a naturally occurring discourse (priorly collected by you) to illustrate your answer.
3. Using examples of utterances occurring in your naturally occurring discourse in 2 above illustrate any three of Searle’s categories of illocutionary acts.

LECTURE 9

GRICE'S MAXIMS AND CONVERSATION



9.1 INTRODUCTION

In Lectures 4, 5 and 6 you learned that a Discourse can be a conversation between two or more people. A conversation between two or more people as you saw in Lectures 6 and 7 is orderly and progresses smoothly until communication is effected and actions are satisfactorily performed. In this lecture you will find out how the conversation progresses smoothly, with every participant making a contribution to the development of the conversation and the communication of messages and achieving of effects among the participants. You will learn that the smooth flow and development of a conversation, together with the successful communication that takes place is as a result of cooperation among the participants in the conversation who are obeying certain Maxims (rules) of Conversation.



9.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Name, define and give your own illustrations of the various Maxims of Conversation according to Grice (1975).
- Identify and write down naturally occurring exchanges in which each of the maxims guide the conversation's progress.
- Compare and contrast the different maxims of conversation.
- Illustrate various examples where flouting of maxims may occur and explain the reasons for their occurrence.



9.3 GRICE'S MAXIMS AND HOW THEY GUIDE CONVERSATION

Participants in a conversation normally proceed according to a principle that is known and applied by all human beings consciously or unconsciously. The idea that conversations proceed

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according to a principle, was first proposed by a philosopher known as Paul Grice (1975). He called this principle, which guides conversation, the **Co-operative principle**.

According to the **Co-operative principle**, people interpret language on the assumption that its producer is obeying four Maxims. In other words, the cooperative principle is stated in terms of four maxims of conversation, namely:

- (i) Maxim of Quality
- (ii) Maxim of Quantity
- (iii) Maxim of Relevance
- (iv) Maxim of Manner

i) Maxim of Quality

This maxim is also known as the maxim of **Truth/Truthfulness**. According to it, the receiver of an utterance assumes that the producer of the utterance is being truthful. The maxim requires that a conversationalist, the speaker, must say only what he/she believes to be true. Instructions to participants in a conversation, according to this maxim are:

1. Do not say what you believe to be false.
2. Do not say that for which you lack adequate evidence.

It is assumed, according to Grice's maxim of Quality/Truthfulness, that a contribution in a conversation will be truthful, unless marked as a deviation from the norm. This maxim is necessary for communication in, and development of, a conversation, because how does one respond to the message from a speaker if one cannot tell whether or not it is true, or whether the speaker is joking or serious? Since this maxim is always in operation in a conversation, if I met you and said to you "what is your name?", your response automatically would be, for instance, ("My name is Eric Ayal"). You would believe that I really want you to tell me your name. It would be abnormal, other factors being constant, if instead of telling me your name you responded by saying, "Really, you are asking me my name" unless you wanted to communicate something more (See Flouting of Maxims in section 8.2.1 below).

ii) Maxim of Quantity

According to this maxim, the interpreter assumes that the producer of language is being brief. Being brief here concerns the quantity of contribution based on the information offered at a particular point in the development of the conversation. The contribution must be to the point, only providing the information required at that particular stage / point in the development of the conversation. It should not be so brief that the message is left unclear. It must be long if necessary. It should just be brief or long **enough**. The instructions according to the Maxim of Quantity are as follows:

1. Make your contribution to the conversation as brief as required for the current purpose of the exchange, in other words,
2. Do not offer/give more information than required.

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For example, if you are asked your name, just say your name and wait to be asked more, either verbally or non-verbally, about yourself, before you give more information about your self or as the saying goes, ‘display your CV’.

iii) Maxim of Relevance/Relation

According to this maxim, the interpreter assumes that the producer of language is being relevant. It requires that each person participating in the discourse/conversation makes a contribution which is relevant to the topic of discussion. This is because if a message is to be communicated then the utterance being produced must bear meaning that follows on logically to what has gone before it. The instruction to the participant according to this maxim is simply:

1. Be relevant.



Note

Note that the maxims of Quantity and Relation or more are less the same but their difference comes in that Quantity deals with the amount of information required at a particular point, while Relation deals with whether the information is on the right topic or not.

iv) Maxim of Manner/Clarity

According to this maxim the interpreter carries on, on the assumption that the producer of language is being clear. It requires that the contribution is neither ambiguous nor obscure. And that the message is conveyed in an orderly way. The instructions according to the maxim are as follows:

1. Be orderly, brief, and clear.
2. Avoid obscurity and ambiguity



What Maxim(s) do you think was violated in the following incident?

“A man whom we shall call Mr. A went to see his friend, Mr. B, who had just come back from a long Journey. Mr. A told his friend that he had come to find out how the journey had been and was interested in the details. Mr. B. quickly remarked that the journey was okay and then he proceeded to give along account of what he wants to do here now that he is back.”



9.3.1 FLOUTING THE COOPERATIVE PRINCIPLE

This is the violation of any one of the four maxims of conversation or the cooperative principle.

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There can be a deliberate violation of a Maxim. This may occur when the producer of language intends the receiver to perceive the utterance as a violation. The receiver should understand such a deliberate violation as a sign that something more is being conveyed in the message. If, however, the producer of the language violates any of the maxims without intending to, then communication breaks down.

Deliberate flouting of the maxims may occur as follows:

Maxim of Quality/Truth

This maxim can be deliberately violated:

- (a) For emphasis, making a point more forceful, as in:.

“My car breaks down every five minutes”

- (b) When using metaphorical language to make a point as in:.

“The earth is a football pitch, and every human being a football player on the pitch.”

- (c) For teasing or playfulness. For example, when you know that a person likes to live alone, then you tell him jokingly that you are inviting him to live with you for one year.
- (d) When a speaker wants to be ironical or sarcastic. For example when you say to a dwarf person: ***“You are very tall”***
Etc.

Utterances deliberately violating the Maxim of Truth are usually accompanied by special intonation, which highlights them as conveying more.

Maxim of Quantity

This maxim may be violated when:

- (a) The speaker wants to make a sense of an occasion. Here a contribution is made unnecessarily long like in speeches made at weddings, or political rallies.
- (b) The speaker wants to be rude, blunt or forthright. Here the speaker may construct an unnecessarily short message or remain silent when a question is asked.

Maxim of Relevance

This can be flouted to signal:

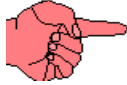
- (a) Embarrassment (E.g., when you say something ridiculous and you are asked to say it again but you don't).
- (b) Desire to change subject (E.g., When you give irrelevant answers to questions)
- (c) Lack of interest in the discourse. (E.g., when your response is too brief and vague where an elaborate account is needed).

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Maxim of Manner/Clarity

Speakers may decide to violate the Maxim of Clarity when they want to:

- (a) Obscure meaning in order to exclude overhearers or unconcerned parties, thereby building solidarity with the one spoken to.
- (b) Misrepresent a message in order to destroy the reality, show humour, or other motives like concealing the truth.



Note that there is another principle of conversation namely the principle of Politeness. This principle is stated in three Maxims:

- Don't impose
- Give options
- Make your receiver feel good

All these maxims are important for a conversation to run smoothly for effective communication.



9.4 SUMMARY

You have seen that, for a conversation to run smoothly for effective communication, participants in the conversation are guided by the Cooperative Principle. This principle requires the participants in a conversation to be truthful, to provide only necessary information, stick to the point or topic of discussion, and be perspicuous. If they fail to do these then there is either breakdown of communication or additional meaning is to be interpreted. So, that is how people proceed in a conversation.

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ACTIVITY

1. What maxim has been violated in each of the following Exchanges and why?

- (a) A: Have you been digging the trench all by yourself?
B: Yes. I hoped you would come to help. Now I am about to die.
- (b) A: Where are you going to?
B: London via Paris. I will stay in London for one year, participating in high profile academic for a.
- (c) A: Have you seen my mother?
B: Yes.

2. Why do we need to be guided by Conversational Maxims when talking?

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BY OCHIENG BRIAN MASJID

LECTURE 10

CREATION OF COHESION AND INTERPRETATION OF COHERENCE IN DISCOURSE



10.1 INTRODUCTION

In this lecture you will find out what makes a discourse one unit. As you saw in Lecture 1, a discourse may be as short as one sentence or even shorter. On the other hand, it may be long, stretching over many sentences, paragraphs or even more. Whether a discourse is short or long, it is one unit, with different parts that combine together to form the whole. The parts are linked together by formal linguistic features known as **cohesion**. The different parts of a discourse work together to express a message, which is perceived as unified and making sense. The perceiving of a discourse as unified and making sense is Coherence. You will learn more about how unity is created and perceived in this lecture.



10.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Tell how unity comes about in discourse
- Tell what coherence in discourse is
- Explain the difference between cohesion and coherence in discourse
- Identify cohesive features in discourse



10.3 UNITY IN DISCOURSE/TEXT

One of the fundamental properties discourse is that: Discourse is structured or organized, and hence has units that can be analyzed systematically. Another important characteristic of Discourse is that it is unified. As you interpret and analyze a piece of discourse, you can perceive a sense of unity in the stretch of language which consists of more than one sentence. All the bits

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and pieces of a discourse (e.g., sentences/utterances, paragraphs or sections hang together and you understand them as forming one whole unity. Thus, there is unity in discourse. It is the unity that is found in discourse that makes the discourse different from a list of sentences? This unity in discourse is achieved by the following three features, among others:

- (i) The features of context: these concern the different aspects of the participants' knowledge of the world. Please see how the **Features of Context** are explained in Lesson 1
- (ii) The message you are communicating to the hearer.
- (iii) The formal linguistic features: these are the words, the sentences, the grammatical rules, semantic meanings of words and expressions used in the occurring discourse.

In discourse analysis you use the concepts, **cohesion** and **coherence** to talk about unity in discourse or text. This is because cohesion and coherence create unity in text, as you will see explained below.



10.3.1 COHERENCE AND UNITY IN DISCOURSE/ TEXT

Coherence is a bit difficult to describe because it is in the perception of the receiver of the discourse - the hearer or reader. When a receiver of a text feels that the message coming through the text is making sense, and is easy to perceive, then we say that that text is coherent. Coherence concerns the unity of the message communicated and perceived by the reader. In order for the readers/hearers to perceive coherence, they are helped by their knowledge of the world. The knowledge of the world includes the knowledge of the language used to communicate the message together with the other features of context.

Consider the following utterances:

- [1] Give me back the **pen** I lent you yesterday.
- [2] **It** is not here.

The meaning of the two sentences is perceived as unified. Sentence[2] is interpreted to provide the response to [1] and it is saying that the pen cannot be given back yet. The two sentences /utterances hence communicate a coherent message. Also there is cohesion, in the form of the grammatical link between **pen** and **it**, which shows the Coherence. Cohesion helps to show Coherence, but Coherence depends on more than Cohesion.

In this unit you need to learn mainly about cohesion. The following section presents you with a description of cohesion and how it creates and shows unity in text/discourse.



10.3.2 COHESION AND UNITY IN DISCOURSE/TEXT

Cohesion concerns the formal linguistic features - the lexical and grammatical items that hold discourse together. These are the words and sentences that build the discourse/text. In Discourse Analysis we identify and describe the formal linguistic features that operate across the

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sentences/utterances in discourse. We call them **cohesion** or **cohesive devices**. They create unity in a discourse/text. They show how a succession of sentences is a discourse unit and not just a list of unconnected sentences. When you look for cohesion in a text, you are looking for the words or expressions or other structural units connecting the different parts of the text.

Cohesive devices are very useful in identifying a discourse, even where very limited features of context are given, particularly in written discourse/text. This is because they mark links among the clauses and sentences of the written text in objective (physical terms). They also mark the links among the utterances and turns in speech. With cohesion, the different segments that form the discourse are therefore perceived or interpreted together as a unit. Consider, for example, the cohesive links shown by the arrows in the following example.

[1] Mrs. Njau was looking for her sons. [2] Two hours had passed since the poor mother sent the lads to buy some paraffin from a nearby petrol station. [3] Mrs. Njau decided to go after the boys [4] She was shocked to find the naughty boys busy playing football by the road side.

In this text examples of cohesive links created among the sentences are as follows:

→ Mrs. Njau [1] = the poor mother [2] = Mrs. Njau [3] = she [4]
 → her sons [1] = the lads [2] = the boys [3] = the naughty boys [4]

To understand how cohesion works to show the unity in text you must recognize and explain features of cohesion. Linguists have come up with various ways of classifying cohesive devices. Among such linguists are, for instance, Cook (1989) who identifies the following categories of cohesion:

- Cohesion by Verb Form: Here verbs of the different sentences of a text connect by taking a uniform form. For example:
 [1] It **rained**. [2] Farmers **planted**.
 where the verbs are both of the actions are in the past tense form.
- Cohesion by Parallelism: Here sentences with parallel grammatical structures are used. For example,
 [1] The days were becoming longer and longer.
 [2] The weather was becoming warmer and warmer.
- Cohesion by Referring Expressions: Here reference words are used as is explained in section 9.3.1.1 below.
- Cohesion by Repetition and Lexical chains: Here words with similar meanings are used as explained in section 9.3.1.4. below

Cohesion by

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- Substitution
- Ellipsis, and
- Conjunction.

Explained in sections 9.3.1.2, 9.3.1.3 and 9.3.1.4. respectively.

Other linguists who have described cohesive features are Halliday and Hasan whose description has been very influential. Halliday and Hasan's description is represented below to help you understand cohesion and how it creates links in text.



10.4 SUMMARY

We have said that unity in discourse/text is created by two things. These two are cohesion and coherence and others that we are not talking about in this module. For a discourse /text to be understood well and for effective communication, participants in the discourse should convey a unified message. This is coherence. Also its sentences and larger units –such as paragraphs of the text should be linked by formal linguistic features, This is cohesion. You will learn more about Cohesion in the next lecture.

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ACTIVITY

1. How do you create unity in discourse/ text?
2. Reconstruct from your memory a discourse/text that you recently participated in.
3. Discuss the characteristics that you think make this discourse /text (in 2 above) unified.

LECTURE 11

BY OCHIENG BRIAN MASJID

HALLIDAY AND HASAN'S DESCRIPTION OF COHESION



11.1 INTRODUCTION

In this lecture you will find out more about the formal linguistic feature that create cohesion in discourse / text. You will study a description of these features according to Halliday and Hassan description of Cohesion in English, and explore examples that show how these categories of cohesion show links in the different parts , segments of a discourse.

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11.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Identify cohesive features in discourse
- Describe the different cohesive categories
- Create cohesion in your own discourse



11.3 HALLIDAY AND HASAN'S DESCRIPTION OF COHESION

Halliday and Hasan (1976) have a classification of cohesion, which distinguishes five major categories of cohesive devices, all of which are included in the Cook's categories above. They are:

- i Cohesion by Reference
- ii Cohesion by Substitution
- iii Cohesion by Ellipsis
- iv Cohesion by Lexical ties
- v Cohesion by Conjunction

These types of cohesion can be placed under two broad categories known as

- i) Grammatical Cohesion
- ii) Lexical Cohesion



11.3.1 GRAMMATICAL COHESION

Under this belongs cohesion by Reference, Substitution, Ellipsis and Conjunction. They belong here because each one of them is defined and described in terms of its grammatical properties.

The grammatical properties include:

- Word classes such as Nouns, Pronouns, Adjectives, Adverbs, Verbs, Prepositions, and Conjunctions.
- Constituent structure concerning, for example, the sentential slots filled by sentence structural units.
- Rules of grammar involving grammatical categories such as, concord, number, tense, and gender; selectional restrictions or co-occurrence rules (e.g., Transitive Verbs take Objects while most Intransitive Verbs do not: E.g., “John kicked (TRANSITIVE) the ball”; “He slept” (INTRANSITIVE)”; Linking Verbs take Complements: for example “The baby became big” (LINKING)

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Using such rules then, you may identify Cohesion by, for example Ellipsis, as in the following sequence:

- [1] Is he tall
[2] Yes he is (---)

The grammatical slot marked (---) is to be filled by the Adjective **tall** just like in the previous utterance.



11.3.2 LEXICAL COHESION

Under this belongs cohesion by use of words and expressions that share semantic meaning hence creating Lexical ties within the text. The words are seen to create Lexical Cohesion because they are defined and described in terms of their lexical semantic properties. The latter are word meanings as defined by semantics. It includes repetition of a word in same or different forms; meaning relations such as synonymy – sameness in meaning; antonymy – oppositeness of meaning; and hyponymy - superordinate/general to particular meaning; and semantic field such as MOVEMENT: walk, run, jog, crawl etc.

You are provided with more descriptions of the above Halliday and Hasan's categories of Cohesion after the activity below.



ACTIVITY

- (1) Indicate whether the Cohesion created by the enbolded/bracketed/underlined words in the following text extract is GRAMMATICAL Cohesion or LEXICAL Cohesion.

[1] In many countries **couples** are expected to know each other very well before **they** (marry). [2].Once **they** do so, there should be no surprises. [3] (Marriage) is a lifelong commitment. [4]**Bridegrooms** must know this before **they** make the commitment.



11.4 COHESION BY REFERENCE

Reference is a grammatical cohesive device. Cohesion by Reference occurs when words are used in the text and the meaning of those words can only be retrieved or discovered by referring to:

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- Other words or phrases in the text, or
- Elements of the context of situation which are clear to both the addressor (speaker/writer) and addressee (listener/reader).

11.4.1 PERSONAL PRONOUNS

The most obvious example of reference items that create cohesion in a discourse are the **personal pronouns** and their possessive counterparts. You can see them in the table below:

She	Her	Herself	Hers
He	Him	Himself	His
It	It	Itself	Its
They	Them	Themselves	Their/Theirs
I / We	Me/ Us	Myself/Ourselves	My/Mine

These items in the table when used in a long stretch of discourse make a kind of chain running through the discourse. In this chain each referential expression is linked to others by co-reference. Co-reference means sharing the same meaning. The items that co-refer have the same referent. Such a chain, a co-reference chain, creates unity in discourse. This kind of unity is known as cohesion by Reference or Reference cohesion. It can be shown by formal linguistics features (e.g., words and rules of grammar). Consider the following discourse extract for example.

(1) The **school teacher** was leaving the village, and everybody seemed sorry.(2) The miller at Ruiru Market lent **him** an old pickup to carry **his** belongings to the city of **his** destination, about 20 km away.(3) Such a vehicle proved of quite sufficient size for the departing **teacher's** effects.

This extract shows deferent words, which create cohesion by reference as in the following chain illustration:

School teacher → **him** → **his** → **his** → **teacher's**

The items **him**, **his**, **his**, refer back to **School teacher**, their meaning can only be interpreted by referring back to the expression 'school teacher' which occurs in the first clause of the text. The word **teacher's** is linked back to **school teacher**, by lexical cohesion. The expression **school teacher** is the referent of all the reference items occurring in the discourse extract. The referent for **him** and **his**, in this example, is found by looking back to a preceding part of the text, hence they are referred to as **Anaphoric Reference**. Anaphoric Reference occurs when the reference item refers back to a previously mentioned noun.

Consider the following other example showing the occurrence of Anaphoric Reference:

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[1] **The buyer** wanted to know how to operate the machine.

[2] **He** asked to be given some instruction.

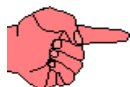
The Reference item **He** in [2] refers back to **The buyer** in [1]

The Reference item can also point ahead as in the following example.

[3] **He** wanted to know how to operate the machine.

[4] That's why **the buyer** asked to be given some instruction.

To interpret **he** in [3], one must look forward to **the buyer** in [4]. When a reference item points ahead it is known as **Cataphoric Reference**.



Note

Cataphoric Reference is very useful in news stories and in fiction where it is used to engage and hold the reader's attention because it means that the reader has to read on and find the meaning of the Reference item. It creates suspense.

Anaphoric and Cataphoric Reference are features of text unity found within the text. They belong to the **Endophoric Reference**, which is reference inside the text. In discourse there is also the possibility of referring 'outward' from the text to identify the referents of reference items. This happens when backwards (Anaphoric Reference) or forwards (Cataphoric Reference) within the text does not supply the necessary information. Looking outwards for a referent often directs us to the immediate context outside the text. This kind of reference is referred to as **Exophoric Reference**. An example of this is when a speaker says:

"Leave **it** on the table please."

Where **it** means some object that you (the hearer) are carrying in your hands, which you want to hand over to the speaker, who then tells you to 'leave **it** on the table'.

Also Exophoric Reference may occur when for instance, the referent is not in the immediate context but is assumed by the speaker/writer to be part of the shared world, either in terms of knowledge or experience. In English the definite article **the**, as a determiner, often acts in this way, as shown in the following examples:

The government is to blame for unemployment.

The people are suffering

I work with **the** army/the police/the church

We will go in **the** car.

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What grammatical word class(es) does cohesion by reference involve?

OTHER REFERENCE ITEMS

Cohesion by Reference is not achieved by the personal pronouns only. Other reference items that create cohesion in a discourse are: the demonstrative pronouns; the definite article, **the**; and the comparative words.

The Demonstrative Pronouns

The Demonstrative pronouns are four in number: **this, these, that, those**

These words are also known as deictic items – meaning words, which identify by pointing. To achieve cohesion the demonstratives work in the same way as the personal pronouns. That is, they have no meaning by themselves. For their meaning to be interpreted it must be retrieved from the surrounding text by referring back or forward within the text, or you will find its meaning outwards in the setting. In the following example the demonstrative **this** creates a cohesive link with italicized parts of the text.

[1] Those who are complaining about **churches praying overnight** are not saying that those religious groups have no right to pray.

[2] They are simply and quite correctly, pointing out that **this** shouldn't happen in a manner that would inconvenience others.

The use of Demonstratives to create reference cohesion can be Anaphoric, Cataphoric and even Exophoric as in the following examples.

[1] The Union's patience has run out over the prolonged delay in implementing the memorandum.

[2] **This** has caused an unnecessary anxiety within the workforce - ANAPHORIC

[3] What we need to do is **this**. [4] We need to start working on the proposal immediately

- CATAPHORIC

[4] John wanted to buy a new shirt. [5] **That** is why he went to town yesterday. -

- ANAPHORIC

[6] I do not like the shoes I am putting on. [7] I like **those**. - EXOPHORIC



What does the underlined Demonstrative in the example [7] –[8] below refer to? Is it Anaphoric or Cataphoric reference?

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- [7] What seems to elude proponents of the night prayers is a sense of balance, tolerance, and being sensitive to the rights of other people.
- [8] ***This*** is perhaps because of the freedom of worship that the law guarantees to every Citizen.

The Definite Article

The Definite Article, which occurs with a repeated or a known item, achieves cohesion by showing that the item with which it is occurring is known from surrounding text or from knowledge of the world. For example:

- [1] ***The schoolteacher*** was leaving the village.
- [2] Such a vehicle proved of quite a sufficient size for ***the teacher's*** effects.

Reference cohesion is created by the use of:

The schoolteacher → ***the teacher's***

in the first and second sentences of the text. The use of ***the*** here helps in identifying the teacher as the schoolteacher who was leaving the village.

The Definite Article often marks items for which the referent must be found by looking outside the text into the participants shared knowledge of the world. For Example: the government, the president, the sun, the moon, and the earth

The Comparative Word

Cohesion by reference may also be created when a comparative word is used the meaning of which cannot be interpreted without looking at other segments of the discourse. For instance,

- [1]The shopkeeper sold me 2 kgs. of sugar.
- [2]I was not satisfied because I needed ***more*** sugar

Without the first sentence [1], one would definitely ask – more than what? This information must be retrieved elsewhere in the discourse. Other examples of comparative words used to create cohesion in discourse are: some, similar, same, and etc.

CONCLUDING REFERENCE COHESION

We have seen that Reference cohesion belongs to grammatical cohesion. The reference words involved must refer elsewhere inside or outside the text. They must belong to either the same grammatical word class as their referent, or be occupying the same sentential slot.

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ACTIVITY

2. Identify each of the words that create Reference Cohesion in the following text extract and provide a chain illustration of the links created.
3. To which sub-types of Reference Cohesion does each of the words you have identified belong.

A tired taxi driver was being called a hero today for his honesty. He returned K shs. 10,000/= in cash that he found in the back of his taxi. Taxi driver Samuel Omenda had just pulled in to a petrol station in Nairobi City at 9.00am when he noticed a black purse, on the floor. In the purse he found K shs. 10,000/= , an ID, a handkerchief and a small note book. Immediately Mr. Omenda started looking for, from the note book, any contacts that could lead him to the owner of the items...



11.5 COHESION BY SUBSTITUTION

Cohesion by substitution occurs when a word / expression is used in the place of another to occupy a structural slot in the sentence. For Example:

[1] Do you *like bananas*?

[2] Yes I *do*

Like bananas in the first sentence is substituted by *do* in the second sentence.

[3] Jane went to *collect her father's books from the office*.

[4] Jane's mother was very annoyed with her because she had told Jane not to *do so*.

Do so substitutes *collect her father's books from the office*.

The words or expressions in the sentence or the parts of the sentence substituted belong to different levels of grammar. They may be:

- Nominal – a noun phrase in the sentence structure.
'I offered the visitor *a seat*. He said he did not need *one*.'
- Verbal – a verb in the sentence structure. This is normally achieved by the word DO. For example,
'Did Kamau *read* the book?'
'He might have *done*.'

Where *done* substitutes for read the book, which is a verb phrase in the structure of the clause.

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They may also be:

- Clausal – where a whole clause is substituted by the word **so** or **not** as in:
'Do **you need a lift to town?**' If **so**, wait for me.
If **not**, I will see you there.'

‘I think **so**’

In these examples the whole clause, "*you/I need a lift to town*", is substituted by **so** in two of the examples and **not** in one.

The link between the substituting item and the one being substituted is grammatical: the element you use in place of another must be of the same type in terms of the word class and more so structural unit of the sentence or the sentence element.



Note

That it is sometimes difficult to separate the various types of cohesion. For instance cohesion by Reference and cohesion by Substitution, since they both concern the use of an element in place of another. One important distinction is that Reference items involve mainly nouns and pronouns. Substitutions involve the phrasal and clausal parts of the sentence: For example, the Verb Phrase substitute by DO and the clausal elements substituted by SO or NOT. And, whereas the Reference item can occur anywhere in a sentence, The substituting element must occur in the same grammatical position as what it is substituting. For example:

Junior arrived at school late. **HIS** teacher was not happy with **HIM**.
Noun Pro N, Modifier Pro. N, Object

Do you like bananas? Yes I DO.
Verb Phrase Verb Phrase

The Reference items **co-refer**. The substitutes **substitute**.

11.6 COHESION BY ELLIPSIS

Sentence grammar states the sentence parts that must be present for a sentence to be complete. Ellipsis is the omission of such parts that are required by the sentence grammar. The speaker/writer omits the part assuming it is obvious from the co-text and therefore need not be mentioned. Thus, when Ellipsis occurs the sentence structure has some ‘missing’ element. The missing element must be retrieved verbatim (word for word) from the surrounding text. For Example, Ellipsis in the following example is marked by (...).

[1] The children will carry the small **boxes**.

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[2] The adults (.....) the large (....).

English has three types of Ellipsis:

- Nominal – involving the omission of noun headword, as in .

[1] Jane likes the green **leaves**.

[2] I liked the yellow (.....).

In this example **leaves** is omitted and it is a Noun, the headword of the NP- ‘the yellow leaves’.

- Verbal – involving the omission of a verbal element, as in

[1] Will anyone **be waiting**?

[2] I will. (.....)

Be waiting which is a verbal element is omitted.

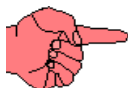
- Clausal – involving the omission of an entire clause, as in,

[1] Would you like a break?

[2] Yes (.....)

The whole of the clause: ‘**We / I would like a break**’ is omitted.

What is left out in Ellipsis is understood and does not need to be said to make the meaning clear.



Note

ELLIPSIS and SUBSTITUTION are similar in that they both operate either at the nominal, verbal or clausal levels. In fact, one may say that Ellipsis is a kind of Substitution: Substitution by ZERO (i.e., nothing)

11.7 COHESION BY LEXICAL TIES

Lexical ties involve vocabulary items (i.e., words) and their meanings. Cohesion by lexical ties occurs in a discourse when related vocabulary items are found across clause and sentence boundaries in written texts, and across turn boundaries in speech. Related vocabulary can occur in a discourse in many ways. One of the most usual ways is by **Lexical Reiteration**. **Reiteration** means:

- (i) Either restating an item in a later part of the discourse by direct repetition of an expression, or
- (ii) Reasserting the expression’s meaning by exploiting **lexical relations**

Lexical relations are the stable semantic relationships that exist between words and which are the basis of descriptions given in dictionaries and thesauruses. They include the relations of:

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- Synonymy – sameness of meaning
- Antonymy – Oppositeness of meaning
- Hyponymy - Superordinate / general – particular meaning relationships.

REITERATION/REPETITION

Repetition is illustrated by the marked words in the following text extract (from Alice in Wonderland)

[1]“When I use a **word**,” Humpty Dumpty said, in a rather scornful tone. “it means just what I choose it to mean... The question is, “ Said Alice, “whether you can make **words mean** so many different things”

SYNONYMY

When a word and its synonym is used and repeated throughout the discourse unity and cohesion is strengthened, as in the example below, where the underlined words are synonymous.

[2] The **schoolteacher** was leaving the village.

[3] Such a vehicle proved of quite a sufficient size for the departing *teacher's* effects.

HYPONYMY

Hyponymy is illustrated in the example below. **Furniture** is the hyponym of all the other bolded and italicized words.

[4]There was a fine old **rocking-chair** that his father used to sit in, a **desk** where he wrote letters, a nest of small **tables** and dark imposing **book case**. Now all this furniture was to be sold, and with it his past.

Hyponymy is the lexical relation involving a superordinate word that covers the meanings of a number of individual words. Thus, **furniture** in the above example is superordinate. The superordinate need not be an immediate superordinate in the family tree of a particular word. It can be a **general word**. (see Halliday and Hasan 1976: Chap. 6). For instance, instead of furniture in the above example, we could have had any of these:

{ Items
Objects
Things } General words/General superordinates.

Other general superordinates, cover humans and animal domains, such as **people**, **creature**; and abstract areas like, **idea**, **fact**.

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ACTIVITY

- 1.(a)Construct your own imaginary text where cohesion is created by lexical ties.
(b)Mark the lexical ties by indicating the words which share meaning.
2. What is the superordinate term in the following extract and what is the particular word that relates to it in meaning?

[1] Millions of lives have been saved, thanks to penicillin. [2]This miracle drug was discovered in 1928 by a Scottish doctor and researcher named Alexander Fleming.



11.8 COHESION BY CONJUNCTION

Conjunction is a grammatical word class. Items belonging to this class signal logical and semantic relationships between the sentences in which they occur. They show clearly how one sentence or clause can be interpreted in relation to another sentence next to it. For example, in [1] and [2] below **therefore** shows that [2] is the result/consequence of [1].

- [1] We once disagreed very badly over a certain issue.
[2] **Therefore**, we are no longer friends.

Conjunctions explicitly draw attention to the meaning relationships holding between the propositions expressed in the sentences. Hence, they create cohesion, links, between sentences of a text, and contribute to the sense that the sentences make together.

There are several different kinds of conjunctions that create cohesion in text. A few kinds are listed below and then illustrated one by one.

- Additive Conjunctive Items
- Adversative Conjunctive Items
- Causal Conjunctive Items
- Temporal Conjunctive Items
- Summative Conjunctive Items

(a) Additives

Additives are words that:

- (i) indicate when a clause or sentence is simply adding more information to what has already been said in the preceding clause or sentence. Words/expressions belonging here are such as: and, furthermore, again, moreover, in addition to, and also as seen in the following example:

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[1] Last year, a plane crashed during take – off at the Busia Airstrip, killing Labour minister, Kumaso. [2] **Also**, several other cabinet ministers were injured in the plane crash.

(ii) indicate an elaboration or exemplification of what has been said. Examples here include words like, that is, in other words, and for instance, as in the following sequence:

[1] She is very well trained for that job. [2] For instance, she has a degree in electrical engineering,

(b) Adversatives

These are the conjunctive words that may contrast new information with old information, or put another side to an argument. Conjunctive items here include: on the other hand, however conversely, yet, although, and but, as in the following example:

[1] Juma was the first person to apply for the job, **but** he did not get it.

(c) Causal Conjunction

This class includes the conjunctive words that relate new information to what has already been given in terms of causes. Examples of words included are: as a result, therefore, consequently, because, for this reason, for and so as in the sequence below:

[1] Her work was finished. [2] **So** she turned off the computer.

(d) Temporal Conjunction

This class includes the conjunctive words/expressions, which relate new information to what has already been given in terms of time. It shows time relations. Words belonging to this class include formally, then, in the end, next, as, while, eventually, earlier, later, and at the same time, as can be seen in the following example.

[1] About 760 drivers have been locked out of the matatu business for having criminal records, Transport Minister John Macho said. [2] **At the same time**, he ruled out the Government investing in the industry even as the crisis continued.

(e) Summative Conjunction

These are the conjunctive words which relate new information to what has already been given by pointing at a summary, or indicating a new departure. They show that the text is winding up. The words involved include, hence, finally, in conclusion, to sum up, by the way, well, any way, and thus, as is used in the following extract:

[1] The president has on many occasions assured us clean elections. [2] But, that has never been true. [3] We have seen cases of misplaced ballot boxes, late delivery, fake IDs and so on. [4] This is why Kanu held on to power for so long. [5] **Thus**, we cannot be sure that history will not repeat itself this time.

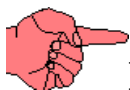
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ACTIVITY

1. Identify the conjunctive items used in the following extract. To what sub-categories of conjunction do they belong?

[1] Before the invention of books, people wrote on stone and clay. [2] Also they wrote on papyrus made from plants in Egypt, or on dried animal skins in the Middle Ages. [3] But to make a book, a real book as we know it today, you need paper and printing.



Note

(I) Conjunction is considered a grammatical type of cohesion even though it is different from Reference, Substitution and Ellipsis. The occurrence of a conjunction does not set off a search backwards or forwards as in the above cases. What a conjunction does is that it presupposes a textual sequence and signals logical relations between segments of the discourse. Thus marking the unity of the discourse networks, and making the different sentences flow smoothly from one to the next, highlighting the sense of unity.

(11) There are many words and phrases that can be put in the category of conjunctions. There are also many different ways in which they can be classified, depending on the ideas they link and how. But we need to emphasize that they form part of the formal links that point to the connections we perceive in the mind when we read or hear sequences of sentences linked by them.

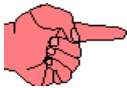
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11.9 SUMMARY

To sum up we can say that cohesive devices provide Discourse Analysis with means of asserting formally and objectively the unity in discourse. Our feeling that a particular stretch of language in some way hangs together, has unity, cannot be accounted for in the same way as our feeling that a sentence is acceptable. The sentence acceptability depends solely on the rules of grammar. The Discourse unity depends on form as well as contexts, and is facilitated by cohesion.

Cohesion can be used to explain in more formal terms why a succession of sentences is a discourse and not just a disconnected jumble, or a list of unconnected sentences. Cohesive devices are very useful in identifying discourse even where very limited features of context are given, especially in written language.



Note

However, we must note that these cohesive/formal links are neither necessary nor sufficient to account for our sense of the unity in discourse, especially spoken discourse. The presence of cohesive devices does not automatically make a language stretch/passage coherent. Also the absence of cohesive devices does not automatically make it meaningless, particularly spoken discourse. For example:

A: Door bell!
B: Am in the bath
A: OK

Although this conversation does not seem to have cohesive features, it is still coherent in the context of situation in which it may occur.

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ACTIVITY

Study the passage below very carefully and then use it to answer the questions 1 to 3 after it

BEING A GOOD PARENT IS EASIER SAID THAN DONE

By KAREN MATTHEWS (Adapted from Daily Nation / Wednesday, November 6 2002)

Sixty-one per cent of parents rate their generation as “fair” or “poor” at raising offspring, according to a recent study that shows parents are struggling in instilling values in their children.

The findings are part of a nationwide survey of parents conducted by Public Agenda, a nonpartisan think tank. The survey found big gaps between parent’s efforts to teach good values to their children and their perceived success in doing so.

While 83 percent said it is “absolutely essential” to teach self- control and self- discipline, only 34 percent said that they have succeeded in teaching those values.

Ninety-one per cent said it is essential to teach honesty, but only 55 per cent said they have succeeded in doing so.

The report also found that 53 per cent of the parents believe they are doing a worse job than their own parents did.

“ This study suggests that, despite the efforts parents are making, they are having trouble,” said Deborah Wadsworth, the president of Public Agenda. “ They have no difficulty laying out a vision of the values they think essential to impart to their child, but succeeding in the job is another matter”

1. Name the categories of all the cohesive devices and their specific sub categories that have been used in this passage.
2. Under each subcategory list all the words and phrases belonging there.
3. Explain how each of the categories of cohesive device you have identified is used in the structure of the text.

LECTURE 12

TOPIC AND INFORMATION STRUCTURE AND THE NOTIONS OF THEME/RHEME (GIVEN/NEW)



12.1 INTRODUCTION

As we wind up this unit, you will find out in this last lecture that another way of describing discourse/text structure is by using topic and information structure and the notions of theme/ rheme (given /new message), which is perceived as making sense.



12.2 OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Tell what topic and information structure, and the notions Theme and Rheme are all about
- Analyze utterances/ sentences and discourse extracts to show topic, Theme and Rheme



12.3 TOPIC AND INFORMATION

When we look at Topic and Information Structure in Discourse Analysis we are concerned with the way of describing discourse that identifies the unifying principle which makes one stretch of discourse about something and another stretch about something else. For example Topic concerns what a discourse stretch is about at whatever level: sentence/utterance, paragraph or even larger stretches. Whatever the discourse is about is its unifying principle, its Topic. One may talk of Sentence Topic and Discourse Topic. And one may wonder how they relate?



12.3.1 SENTENTIAL TOPIC

In the sentence structure, (according to Hockett), a distinction can be made between the Topic and the Comment. In a sentence the speaker announces a Topic and then says something about it. E.g.,

(1) Martha / took tea.
TPC CMNT

(2) The newly married couple / will visit their new home today.
TPC CMNT

The Comment is what the speaker says about the thing announced, the topic.

In the English language, the Topic usually is also the Subject of the sentence, and the COMMENT, the Predicate. However this is not always the case, as in the following example where 'I' is the subject and 'The newly married couple' is the object.

(3) The newly married couple, I have not seen yet.
TPC CMNT

And the Comment is a whole clause – 'I have not seen yet'

So how do we identify in a systematic objective way the Topic of a sentence then?

The Topic is usually put in the Initial position of the sentence, but it depends on the speaker who may mark it in different ways as we shall see later.



12.3.2 DISCOURSE TOPIC

If one were to divide up a lengthy discourse (e.g. a recording of a conversation) into chunks /segments which can be investigated in detail, one may depend on the intuitive notions about where one part of the discourse ends and another begins. This type of decision is usually made by appealing to the intuitive notion of Topic. A segment of conversational discourse, for example, may be treated as a unit of some kind because it is on a particular TOPIC

In Discourse Analysis Topic is not considered as a grammatical constituent of any kind. In a discourse fragment, such as a conversation, Topic is not likely to be identified as one part of a sentence. In fact it is emphasized that "It is not sentences that have Topics but speakers| who do". A discourse topic is not a simple Noun phrase, but a proposition about which some claim is being made or elicited, i.e., It is the "question of immediate concern", or "the issue at hand". It may occur in form of a whole proposition.

This specification of a discourse Topic implies that, for any fragment of a conversational discourse, a single proposition, expressed as a phrase or sentence, represents the discourse Topic of the whole of the fragment.

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According to Tyler (1978:452) the term Topic can only be one possible paraphrase of a sequence of utterances. It is suggested that the Topic of a text or discourse is equivalent to the title, and that for any text there is a single correct expression which is the 'Topic'. But this is not absolutely true. There is a problem with such an understanding of Topic. For one, it is very possible to imagine several different titles for any single passage. And each different way of expressing the 'topic' effectively represents a different judgment of what is being talked or written in the text. The problem is greater when one wants to determine a single phrase or sentence as the 'Topic' of a piece of printed text where fragments of a conversational discourse are considered. In such a discourse, "What is being talked about will be judged at different points. Even the participants will not have identified views of what each is talking about.

Thus, the notion of Discourse Topic as what is being talked about is attractive but it is difficult to attain.

Why is it attractive?

- i) It seems to be the central organizing principle for a lot of discourse.
How?
- ii) It may enable the analyst to explain why several sentences or utterances should be considered together as set of some kind, marking it a separate part from another set.
- iii) It may also provide a means of distinguishing fragments of discourse which are felt to be good coherent examples of text, from those that are incoherent lists of sentences.



12.4 INFORMATION STRUCTURE

Halliday adopted the Prague School view of information as consisting of two categories:

- New Information: this is the information the addressor believes is not known to the addressee.
- Given Information : this is the information the addressor believes is known to the addressee, either because it is physically present in the context or because it has already been mentioned in the discourse.

According to Halliday, Intonation in English is to mark off which of the information the speaker is treating as New and which information is being treated as Given, since the speaker has to chunk his speech (information) into information units – he has to present his information in a series of packages. He is free to decide where the New information starts and ends. E.g. he can decide to have one chunk such as:

“John has gone into the garden with Mary”, or divide it into two chunks e.g.

“ John – has gone into the garden with Mary “ or three chunks , e.g.:

“John - has gone into the garden – with Mary”.

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The internal organization of the Information unit, relates to the way in which Given and New information is distributed within the unit.

Halliday suggests that the speaker will order Given Information before New Information. Thus the 'Unmarked' sequencing / order of information structure equals GIVEN – NEW. Thus the Given information will take the initial position of the unit then it will be followed by the New information. (Like in Theme - naming the Topic which is known and then / Rheme – saying something not known about the Topic.

According to Halliday, Information units are directly realized in speech as 'TONE GROUPS'. Others have named units of a similar kind as 'Breath groups'; Phonic Clauses, or Tone Units. The speaker distributes the quota of the information he wishes to express into these phonologically defined units. Tone groups are distinguished phonologically by containing one and only one Tonic Syllable. The Tonic Syllable is characterized as having the maximal unit of pitch on it. The Tonic Syllable functions to focus the New information in the Tone group.

It is important to note that we should not suppose that the status of information is dictated by whether an entity has been referred to already within the discourse. Halliday consistently and correctly remarks that: These are options on the part of the speaker, not determined by the textual or situational environment. What is new is in the last resort what the speaker chooses to present as new, and predictions from the discourse have only a high probability of being fulfilled (1967:211).

Halliday states that there is a close relationship between the realization of the information unit phonologically in the Tone Group, and Syntactically in the clause: In the unmarked case the information unit will be mapped onto the clause, but the speaker has a choice of making it co-inside with any constituents specified in the sentence structure (1967:242) even the Adverbial.

In Obituaries, encyclopedic entries etc, you are likely to find a 'Given' form refereeing to the Topic entity at the beginning of a clause, which is then followed by New information.

It is reasonable to suggest that information structure is realized partly by syntax (in the thematic structure, I.e., word order) and partly by phonological systems including phonological prominence and pause, We should expect to find regularities in the realization of information structure within these systems.



12.4.1 INFORMATION STRUCTURE AND SYNTACTIC FORMS

Given /New and Syntactic Forms

Harris observes that in English new information is characteristically introduced by indefinite expressions and subsequently referred to by definite expressions when we use the two articles A and THE:

- 'A' - denotes individuals as unknown
- 'THE' – denotes individuals as known

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To explain by example: I see an object pass by, which I have never saw till then. What do I say? “There goes a beggar with along beard”. The man departs and returns a week later. What do I say then? “There goes the beggar with the long beard”. The article only is changed, the rest remains (Harris 1751:215-16).

Some expressions refer to given entities. The expressions that are “given” are underlined in the following examples:

- i) Jane packed some luggage in the car.
 - ii) The luggage was heavy.
 - iii) What happened to the fruits?
 - iv) They were all sour.
- Etc



12.4.2 INFORMATION STRUCTURE AND SENTENCE STRUCTURE

Since written sentences have no intonation, writers assign intonation structure to them by relying on syntactic form of Nominal expressions, and on sentence structure to determine what in the sentence has the status ‘New’ and what has the status ‘Given’ Sentences signal New and Given information by stress and accent on particular words. The word with the stress or a phrase containing it always conveys the new information..

To take a simple example, the sentence: “It was Mary who left” seems to break down into **Given**, “Someone Left”, and **New**: “The someone who left was Mary”.

This is naturally read as “ It was MARY who LEFT”, meaning that Mary and Left are given stress and so treated as new information, where as “it was” and “who” are not stressed and so treated as given information. In such cases the New information has been brought to the front by a syntactic process known as Topicalisation.

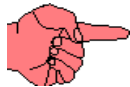
In the Natural order of the English Declaratives, The known/given information is usually placed first/sentence initial, as the Subject of the sentence. It is known as the Theme. The theme is then followed by the Rheme, what is being said about the theme?

The Theme as we saw earlier is the element that serves as the point of departure of the message. It is that which a clause is all about. The remainder of the message, the part in which the theme is developed is called the Rheme. A clause consists of a Theme accompanied by a Rheme and the structure follows that order- whatever is chosen as the Theme is put first.

E.g.,

- The Referendum / has been given credit.
THEME RHEME
- The second semester / is now underway in all the campuses of Kenyatta University
THEME RHEME

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Note

The Theme may also be an Adverbial group or Preposition Phrase and not necessarily a Nominal group thus:

- In all the campuses of Kenyatta University / the second semester is now underway.
 - At early afternoon / she took the books home
 - Once / there was security concern
- THEME / RHEME



Can you identify the link between theme and topic and that between rheme and new information



ACTIVITY

Show Topic/Theme/Rheme/New and Given Information in discourse segments identifiable in this text.

THE TEXT

Next time anything like this that is likely to sap your sanity, happens just follow the example of a Windhoek taxi driver, a car reversed from a parking lot onto the road in front of him, he braked and missed hitting the offending drivers car's car by a whisker. Instead of apologizing, the motorists hurled insults at the taxi driver who instead of hitting back with hard invectives just smiled. Miracle? No the taxi driver's way of seeing things is different from most of us. To him the careless driver is like a garbage truck, full of garbage, running around to dump his anger and frustration at the next available site. The Taxi driver does not want to be that next dumping site.

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12.5 SUMMARY

To sum up we can say that the Topic of a discourse is very useful in understanding discourse function and structure

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